

The Political Roots of Legal Access: Evidence from Village Councils in India*

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Abstract

Politicians have long served as intermediaries for citizens navigating the state. Can elected representatives facilitate citizens' access to the formal justice system? Justice seekers face formidable social and administrative costs that cause most grievances to remain outside the state's purview. Politicians lower these barriers through a distinct form of assistance: by acting as intermediaries. I test this theory in 28,000 village councils in Maharashtra, India, leveraging population-based discontinuities in council size, paired with an original dataset of 3.37 million court cases. I find that additional council members lead to a 51% increase in court filings and qualitative data documents these direct interactions. Surveys of citizens and council elections data show that this phenomenon is explained by greater capacity and descriptive representation in larger councils. These findings reveal how political institutions act as a catalyst for legal mobilization.

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1 Introduction

Citizens across the world face significant barriers to justice: globally, over two-thirds of the population has unmet civil and criminal justice needs (World Justice Project [2019](#)). As legal issues remain unresolved, individuals risk losing their livelihoods, property, and fundamental human rights. Access to justice is therefore critical for protecting these rights and maintaining social stability—and courts form the central institutions where grievances can be resolved.

These grievances range from everyday justice issues, such as land disputes, to severe instances of crime and corruption. However, the vast majority of grievances face a series of obstacles before they reach the courts, leaving vulnerable citizens outside the protection of the rule of law. Faced with these barriers, citizens seek guidance from the most proximate state authority—typically, an elected representative. Although elected officials have long acted as intermediaries for citizens navigating the state (Stokes et al. [2013](#)), this paper offers new evidence on how they also play a critical role in helping citizens access the formal justice system.

Empirically identifying whether elected officials engage in this type of work is challenging. While surveys can capture individual experiences with the justice system, the small subset of the population engaged in disputes makes it difficult to generate representative samples. Further, endogenous factors—like litigants’ social capital and geographical proximity—determines whether they approach courts. I overcome these limitations by combining a novel administrative dataset with a regression discontinuity design (RDD) focused on Maharashtra, India. First, I assemble an original dataset of over 3.3 million cases involving litigants from over 28,000 villages, that allows me to precisely measure legal access at the village level for 1.2 million cases. These cases are filed in the District Courts of Maharashtra, the courts of first instance. Second, my identification strategy exploits a unique rule where two additional elected officials are assigned to the village councils at strict, population-based cutoffs, providing a source of exogenous variation in the size of the village council. The Indian context is also substantively important, given that citizens face multiple stages of discretion and discrimination as they seek to access formal state institutions (Jassal [2024](#)).

I find that increasing the size of the village council increases access to the justice system. Specifically, I find that the case filing rate increases from a baseline of 1.1 cases to 1.7 cases—corresponding

to a 51% increase in case filings. Further, I use the rich metadata associated with each case to determine whether a case involves a civil or criminal issue. I find similar sized effects for both criminal and civil cases—while the number of criminal cases increases by 48%, the number of civil cases increases by 62%. Finally, I use information on case decisions to show that political influence is limited to the filing stage of a case but cannot influence its timely adjudication.

I carry out additional tests to ensure that these results are not sensitive to the choice of bandwidth, districts in the sample and functional form assumptions. I obtain consistent results in employing two alternate empirical strategies: (i) by leveraging a regression discontinuity aggregation (RDA) design that uses the data on all 3.3 million cases with treatments defined at the sub-district level and (ii) extending the RDA results by accounting for possible missing cases by leveraging the serialized nature of the case numbers (Wu et al. 2026) to measure outcomes.

I supplement the quantitative analysis drawing upon two distinct sets of qualitative data that highlight the ways in which council members act as intermediaries. First, informational interviews with 19 council members confirm that council members employ different strategies to deal with civil and criminal issues in their village. Second, a coding of field notes from shadowing council presidents (Bussell 2020b) provide evidence on how the officials intervene to help citizens register cases with the police.

I proceed to explore the theoretical mechanisms underscoring the increase in legal access. The literature on state capacity as pointed out that the addition of political, bureaucratic and judicial resources can lead to large immediate and downstream benefits (cite). Furthermore, the increase in capacity can be based on the both the number and type of representatives. «cite, who is the politician matters». Thus, the increase in access can be driven both by the expansion of human resource capacity to assist with complex legal grievances, and greater descriptive representation.

To test these patterns, I assemble additional data on council elections, council members, election timing, the census and two surveys, first from the Rural Demographic and Economic Survey of India (REDS-2006) and the Indian Human Development Survey (IHDS-2011).

I leverage a natural experiment within the REDS-2006, where population growth triggered the assignment of additional council members in some villages, to show that respondents in villages

with larger councils had better evaluations of council members' quality and problem-solving ability. This shows that increasing the size of the council increases its capacity to serve citizens.

Next, I use rich data on council elections (Amar 2025b) and find that larger councils have greater descriptive representation of non-dominant groups—villages with additional seats elect more women and members of marginalized groups, in excess of those accounted by mandatory reservation policies or quotas. Importantly, this increased representation is consequential and leading to substantive representation for women, demonstrated by an increase in filing rate for female litigants.

I also evaluate three alternative explanations that could explain why increasing the size of the council increases legal access. First, larger councils could increase the electoral competitiveness, which in turn increases the responsiveness of council members (Gerring and Veenendaal 2020). However, I find no evidence that the treatment affects electoral competitiveness. Instead, the treatment increases voter turnout by 10%. The higher turnout may be changing the types of elected members, that further supports a mechanism driven by greater descriptive representation. Second, larger councils could change the provision of public goods, particularly those related to the police. Particularly, council members could influence the staffing of the village-level law enforcement officer: however, I show that the smaller and larger sized councils are not systematically different in terms of whether the village police position is filled or not. Finally, a larger council could signal better state capacity and increase trust in state institutions (Hansen 2013). Descriptive analysis using citizen surveys from the IHDS-2011 suggest that the size of the village council is not associated with confidence in the police and courts.

This paper makes three important contributions. First, I propose and test a novel theory on the role of politicians in facilitating access to justice and legal mobilization (Black 1973). The findings underscore how local institutions shape dispute resolution and legal behaviors in weak states (Blattman, Hartman, and Blair 2014; Brulé 2020). Crucially, this paper challenges the assumption that local authorities undermine the rule of law: instead, I show how non-adjudicative political bodies can strengthen formal adjudicative institutions by lowering the barriers to entry (Sarat and J. B. Grossman 1975).

Second, I extend the literature on political decentralization by looking at how a specific factor of institutional design (council size) affects local-level outcomes. While existing research has examined

the effects of legislature size on fiscal policy and public goods (Chen and Malhotra 2007; Höhmann 2017; Lewis 2019; Mignozzetti, Cepaluni, and Freire 2024; Pettersson-Lidbom 2012; Weingast, Shepsle, and Johnsen 1981), I expand this enquiry to study forms of constituency service. As politicians can determine a citizen’s ability to make legal claims, I show that facilitating access to justice can be a form of deliverable political good (Gallagher, Kruks-Wisner, and Taylor 2024).

Finally, this study makes an empirical and methodological contribution to the study of village governments in India. Prior research has noted the role of rural politicians as local intermediaries, shaping the allocation of benefits (Besley, Pande, Rahman, et al. 2004; Besley, Pande, and V. Rao 2012; Chattopadhyay and Duflo 2004; Dunning and Nilekani 2013), access to the state and its resources (Bussell 2019; Kruks-Wisner 2018a), and their contribution to democratic processes (Besley, Pande, and V. Rao 2005; Parthasarathy, V. Rao, and Palaniswamy 2019). I provide a replicable framework for estimating the causal effects of these local governance outcomes—a strategy that can be extended to various Indian states. Furthermore, by assembling a massive village-level dataset encompassing the full universe of cases filed in the lower courts of the Indian judiciary in Maharashtra, this study contributes to the growing body of scholarship that examines the dynamic interplay between law and society at the grassroots level in India (Galanter and Dhavan 1989; Goyal, Van Noort, and Ahrenshop 2022; Kokal 2019; J. K. Krishnan et al. 2014).

2 Theoretical Expectations

Access to justice is a broad concept: researchers and international organizations have linked access to justice to the protection of human rights, social stability and economic development (Deseau, Levai, and Schmiegelow 2025). A core component of this concept is the legal capacity of citizens to overcome physician and social barriers to access formal judicial institutions. Such legal mobilization (Black 1973) enables formal adjudicative institutions (courts) to become involved in the interpretation and management of conflict (Sarat and J. B. Grossman 1975). The structural design of state courts—grounded in codified laws and subject to both public and appellate oversight—renders them uniquely equipped to deliver both procedural and substantive justice.

Histories of disputes show a pyramid-shaped dispute processing and resolution, wherein behavioral

filters reduce the overall volume of cases taken to court. Many justice problems do not end up in court at all—they receive no legal attention, forming unmet legal needs (Sandefur 2019). Would-be litigants evaluate the payoffs of pursuing a claim, consulting a lawyer, filing a lawsuit, and taking the case to trial (Genn 1999). Given that each step is costly, only a fraction of all disputes end up as cases in the formal legal system. The situation is particularly difficult for rural litigants, who face higher costs to getting their legal needs met (A. Hoffman and Strezhnev 2023; J. K. Krishnan et al. 2014).

To address this problem, a growing body of literature highlights the promise of “justice workers”—intermediaries embedded in local communities who help citizens navigate the justice system and overcome barriers in accessing legal remedies (Sandefur and Burnett 2024). While the literature in comparative politics has long documented the role of communities and village-level authorities in dispute resolution—from panchayats in India to customary leaders in Sub-Saharan Africa and Indonesia (Baldwin and Ricart-Huguet 2023; Ellickson 1994; Galanter 1981; Just 2001; Van Der Waal 2004)—this body of research has not yet looked at whether elected politicians can play a role in closing the justice gap by helping citizens approach and access the formal legal system.

As a result, people turn to local informal legal institutions consisting of village elders, local leaders and officials who dispense traditional or customary forms of justice (Gauri 2009). This form of legal pluralism prevalent across the Global South, and surveys across countries have noted the outsized preference for these informal institutions.

In order to help citizens overcome persistent problems of accessing formal legal institutions, countries across the world have considered both demand and supply side reforms. For instance, Indonesia devolved dispute resolution to customary village-level institutions, giving binding authority to village heads (Clark and Stephens 2011), while the Government of Eritrea organized community courts to enable community participation in the justice process (Andemariam 2011). More recently, research has shown how local community mobilization through justice workers (Sandefur and Burnett 2024) can help citizens overcome informational and transactional constraints to pursue legal issues through courts. In what follows, I discuss how politicians can play a very similar role to that of justice workers—in helping citizens overcome constraints and access justice by playing the role of an intermediary.

Elected representatives intervene in local disputes and help citizens access the state since it allows them to demonstrate efficacy, claim credit and signal their competency. By using their influence to intervene between the state, bureaucrats and citizens, representatives can display their concern and responsiveness to the problems faced by their constituents. Helping people with their justice problems has electoral payoffs: representatives gain opportunities for credit-claiming at the time of elections, allowing them to build strong, lasting relationships with their voters which drives the incumbency advantage (King 1991). Such gains can make the representatives willing to help a very broad base of individuals. At the same time, partisan concerns can dominate assistance provided by local representatives: politicians may direct group-oriented goods to their core supporters.

When a citizen approaches an elected representative for help with disputes, the politician's intervention can take two forms: formal institutional facilitation or informal mediation. Two hypotheses follow from this.

First, I hypothesize that representative acts as a procedural guide, helping the aggrieved party navigate the bureaucracy of law enforcement to register formal complaints. Representatives facilitate access to the formal legal system by directly influence disputes that are reported to the state by providing information and advice¹. Next, they can affect disputes that are recorded by the state, since representatives have greater power and influence than common citizens to overcome bureaucratic hurdles. Their presence makes bureaucrats responsive to citizen's complaints through the "long route" of accountability, wherein politicians hold the service providers accountable (Devarajan, Khemani, and Shah 2005). Hence, I expect more citizens to overcome bureaucratic hurdles to access the formal justice system on increasing the number of representatives in a fixed jurisdiction.

H_1 . Increasing the number of elected representatives increases access to the formal justice system

These processes operate in distinct ways for criminal and civil cases. Criminal matters demand systematic investigation, forensic resources, and coercive authority, which make it difficult for representatives to independently adjudicate and enforce criminal judgements (Sternlight 2007). Consequently, for criminalized grievances, politicians facilitate access to formal legal authorities,

¹They can also indirectly influence reporting through a symbolic effect: seeing marginalized groups in positions of power can increase the self-confidence of to approach authorities (Iyer and Mani 2012).

ensuring the dispute enters the official state record where it can be addressed by specialized judicial resources.

On the other hand, civil grievances—such as those involving family disputes, land boundaries or debt—are amenable to mediation because they rely on local knowledge and social consensus. In this case, the representative could a quasi-judicial role, counseling the parties and negotiating a resolution outside the state’s purview (Sarat and J. B. Grossman 1975). Court cases may still be filed if mediation is not effective, or if the issue is complex that it requires systematic investigation by the state. Politicians can serve as intermediaries for such complex cases by providing forms of logistican and informational support: like helping with documentation, affidavits and access to lawyers and legal services.

Increasing the number of elected representatives adds additional human resources to provide assistance to citizens. This increases the capacity of politicians to provide assistance to citizens since it. I test this implication through the following hypothesis:

H₂. Increasing the number of elected representatives increases capacity to help citizens with everyday problems.

Finally, politicians solve these problems for citizens as a form of representation (Pitkin 1967, p. 155). However, not all citizens are equally likely to request assistance from representatives (G. Grossman and Slough 2022), and shared identities play an important role in whether the help is provided. A robust body of literature has found that representatives who share personal characteristics with particular citizens (descriptive representation) leads to greater substantive representation for the group (Broockman 2013; Butler and Broockman 2011; Chattopadhyay and Duflo 2004)— on account of intrinsic, personal concern and political incentives. Since politicians can facilitate access to justice as a service for constituents, political representation of non-dominant groups should increase access to justice for such groups in the justice system.

H₃. Increasing the number of elected representatives improves descriptive representation, increasing access to the justice system for a broad range of citizens

Although the theory focuses on elected representatives serving as intermediaries, it applies more broadly to other non-elected intermediaries with strong incentives to provide services to citizens.

Examples of such intermediaries include village elders, brokers, state officials and “new leaders” (Krishna 2011). It applies also to contexts where individuals have a strong connection to elected representatives. This implies representatives closest to citizens based on geography or social backgrounds are most likely to help with citizens’ legal grievances. In doing so, the theory focuses on individual-level hurdles for dispute resolutions, that are eventually handled by both judicial and political institutions. This is distinct from larger mobilization of larger social and political movements, wherein incentives for political intermediaries are not clear.

Finally, while the theory applies to informal dispute resolution, resolution of formalized disputes is not guaranteed. Political influence cannot influence timely adjudication of disputes through formal institutions if official authorities—the courts and police—are adequately shielded from political interference through the separation of power. Politicians have a weaker ability to influence case-level outcomes such as decision quality, fairness or the time it takes to reach a decision. Thus, while politicians can influence the whether citizens are able to approach legal and law enforcement institutions, they cannot influence the outcomes and resolutions beyond this step.

3 Context: Village Councils in Maharashtra, India

India’s post-independence constitution directed the establishment of local self-government—the earliest rural local government bodies have existed in independent India since 1959, and after 1993, were formalized across all states. In 1993, the Government of India passed the Indian Constitution (73rd Amendment) Act, which mandated the creation of India’s rural representative bodies—the Panchayats. This formalized and decentralized power to the third tier of government. The reform sought to create a three-tier system of local governance comprising *gram panchayats* (village-level bodies), *taluka panchayats* (sub-district level bodies) and *zilla panchayats* (district-level bodies).² Each state was to set up such a three-tier system of local government, whose bodies were to be elected every five years. Additionally, the laws delegated several areas of administration, development and fiscal authority to the elected members.

²These have slightly different names across Indian states. For instance, in Maharashtra, the local bodies are set up in the form of a three-tiered system, wherein the *gram panchayat* is the lowest and most immediate elected-representatives body in a village. The next tier is at the block level (*panchayat samiti*), which forms a smaller area of a district—the councilors chosen from the entire district and chairpersons of the *panchayat samitis* make up the *zilla parishad*.

The law entrusted village councils (*gram panchayats*) with both administrative and developmental functions—states could devolve 29 functional areas to the village councils. These involved activities like managing and monitoring facilities for water provision, sanitation, education, public health and roads (Chaudhary and Iyer 2022). Additionally, health and education monitoring is also carried out by the council members—for instance, the maintenance of schools and monitoring of teachers comes under their purview (Chaudhary and Iyer 2022). Further, the new legislation also called for states to set up State Finance Commissions to provide recommendations on revenue-sharing and making grants to the village councils. However, very few states delegated the control of funds and most of these bodies continue to rely on the central or state governments for their revenues (Chaudhary and Iyer 2022).

Each village council is headed by the ‘pradhan’ who could be elected directly or indirectly. Village council members, including the council head, are the most influential local politicians, who are tasked with implementing public works, social justice projects and land allocation (Brulé 2020). Further, public meetings of the village (*gram sabhas*) approve plans and programs for development, in addition to formal powers of policy implementation (Bussell 2019).

Indian citizens face challenges in accessing the state: officials demand ‘speed-money’ (bribes) and citizens as face long queues at government offices and complicated procedures, they frequently turn to political networks and intermediaries for help (Berenschot 2010). Citizens engaging politicians for intermediation is a form of claim making—62% of survey respondents reported contacting elected members of a village council for help to make such claims on the state (Kruks-Wisner 2018b). While politicians at higher levels (at the block, district, state or national) levels can be approached, citizens identify the village-level politicians as those who have the most power to help individuals access their desired services (Bussell 2019).

Helping citizens access the justice system is a not a scarce resource—helping one citizen with their dispute does not deprive another person of the same service—leading to reputational benefits. This has been observed in urban slum clusters, wherein neighborhood leaders mediate relations with the police (Tellez, Wibbels, and Krishna 2020). While co-partisan citizens expect to receive benefits from their village council president (Bussell 2019), especially in distributing scarce benefits (Schneider and Sircar 2024), the diverse partisanship of members of a village council allows citizens

to approach different members to obtain the same benefit.

India has a long tradition of dispute resolution at the village level— Meschievitz and Galanter (1982) explain that the term *panchayat* means the ‘coming together of five persons,’ and the meeting of five or more members of a village or caste to judge disputes was a prevalent practice. These bodies could be organized along caste lines, based on village boundaries or involve the members of trade guilds or artisan groups to formally or informally hear complaints.³

Courts in India are incredibly overloaded—on a per capita basis, India has only 20 judges per million⁴, while the United States has over 100 and Europe has over 200 judges per million (M. Rao 2024). Moreover, India’s courts are notoriously slow—congested courts delay the resolution of even minor disputes.

The judiciary in India is organized as a three-tier system. The Supreme Court is at the apex level of the Indian Judiciary, often described as the ‘most powerful judiciary in the world’. Further, there are 24 High Courts that encompass states or larger regions, and typically, each administrative district has a District and Sessions Court. Subordinate courts report to the District Court, which hears civil and criminal cases. This paper focuses on the courts of first instance: that is, the District Courts and Subordinate Courts.

Similarly, the Indian police system⁵ is also one of the most under-resourced—India has the second

³While the idea of village panchayats serving as “judiciaries of the village” is not new, the Government of India has tried to approach the challenge of access to justice through two routes. In 2006, the Ministry of Panchayati Raj of the Government of India announced the formation of a committee to prepare a ‘Nyaya Panchayat Draft Bill’, which would involve elected bodies to serve as adjudicators. Press reports suggest that the Law Ministry had expressed objections to this, since in the same period (in 2007), the Ministry of Justice and Law conceptualized the *gram nyayalays*—which decentralizes judicial responsibility to local (village) level judicial bodies in the form of “mobile courts” that are headed by judicial officers who are trained judges (as opposed to elected officials). The ‘Gram Nyayalays Bill’ was eventually passed in 2008 in both houses of the Parliament. While few remain operational, these so-called village-level courts are simply reassigned courtrooms located within existing subordinate courts, thus their title is nominal (Bail 2015).

⁴Judges are recruited based on their performance in competitive judicial examinations, the norms for which vary across states.

⁵Policing in India is organized at central and state level—at the central level, it includes the most elite members of the Indian Police Service (IPS), recruited through a centralized exam, and at the state level, it includes the State Police Services, recruited through a state-level exam. Several “non-gazetted” officers serve under them, comprising Inspector and Sub-Inspectors. Finally, about 85% of Indian police officers are at the ‘Constable’ level, whose daily jobs consist of patrolling, escorting prisoners or running errands for senior officers (Lee 2021). Given the weak capacity of the Indian state, a number of approaches have been taken to distribute the burden of law and order—particularly to local politicians. Unlike in Maharashtra (the focus of this paper), in states like Bihar and Himachal Pradesh, village councils have judicial powers. In particular, in Bihar, village courts called *gram kachaharis* were set up in 2006, which are court-like institutions set up in every *panchayat* for resolving local disputes with the involvement of local people.[~7]

lowest police-to-population ratio in the world (Lee 2021).

3.1 Disputes in Rural India

With such vast gaps in the justice system, when and how do litigants choose to approach courts in India? I discuss findings from recent surveys on this topic. In 2017, a legal think tank in India conducted a nationwide survey to understand the various modes of dispute resolution used in India as a means to access justice.⁶ Fewer than 6% of respondents reported having been involved in a dispute in the past five years.

During the initial stages of a dispute, people turn to trusted sources to understand more about their dispute—approaching friends, family and village elders—particularly, 74% said they would approach family or friends, 49% would approach village elders, and 23% said that they would approach members of the village council.⁷ When asked whom they would not approach, 40% said the police, 32% said lawyers, and 13% mentioned legal service authorities. This highlights an important pattern: at the initial stage of a dispute, people tend to seek advice from those closest to them and generally distrust actors associated with the legal or law enforcement systems.

Among respondents who had experienced disputes and sought resolution, 70% said they would pursue resolution through the courts, while 30% opted for non-court methods. Notably, most respondents who preferred court-based resolution belonged to higher-income groups, whereas those opting for non-court methods were predominantly from lower-income groups. For certain types of disputes—especially those involving the government or police, as in criminal cases—courts remained the preferred method of resolution.⁸

Moreover, surveys that directly enquire about the types of requests made by citizens to politicians—between 6-9% of all requests for assistance made to council members and presidents concern police cases (Bussell 2019, p. 185) This suggests that council members—the elected officials who are

In this paper, I study Maharashtra, where elected representatives *do not* hold legal authority or official mandates to help with disputes.

⁶The survey employed random sampling and collected responses from over 50,000 individuals. The information gathered includes demographic data, perceptions regarding disputes and information on disputes resolved through courts and through non-judicial means.

⁷The percentages are based on multiple-choice responses.

⁸For instance, 91% of disputes with the government, 74% of disputes with the police and 88% of insurance related cases were resolved by court, because of the relative absence of non-court avenues to resolve such disputes.

members of the *gram panchayats*—can influence the filing of formal complaints. They can act as initial advisors to would-be litigants, offering guidance on whether pursuing a case is worthwhile. Thus, qualitative descriptions of the context help support our theoretical expectations: since citizens frequently approach council members with requests, they can influence the degree to which cases are reported formally.

4 Data and Empirical Strategy

4.1 Data

Case-level data from Maharashtra District Courts: The main variable of interest is access to the justice system—whether people approach courts to enforce their legal rights. This is measured by using administrative data on the universe of reported civil and criminal complaints handled by District Courts, the courts of first instance in India. The primary source of this data is the eCourts project, that aims to transform the Indian judiciary by incorporating information and communication technologies.

The eCourts project was designed to strengthen India’s justice delivery, by facilitating digital filings and availability of up-to-date judicial records, that can be easily accessed by members of the public. It involved a large-scale digitization of cases over the last two decades, which were made accessible to the public through a web-based platform. Each case record captures key details in its metadata, which includes the date of filing, acts and sections under which the case was filed, police station responsible (in case of criminal cases), and details of the actors involved (which are the litigants, lawyers and judges). Additionally each case record captures the processing details during the lifetime of the case: indicating the hearings conducted, interim orders (if any), whether a decision has been reached, and occasionally, the text of the judgment.

The main advantage of using this dataset is that the case filings capture whether individuals *meaningfully* accessed the justice system. Using the eCourts data for measuring the legal registration of criminal cases serves as a hard test for the theory: grievances first get formally documented as a ‘First Information Report (FIR)’ by the police, and after preliminary investigation, a charge sheet is created which is filed in the court (Jassal [2024](#)). Pursuing civil litigation in India involves the

payment of processing fees and submitting the a draft of the complaint to the court.

While case filings only considers the complaints that reach courts, a limitation of using this as an outcome is that we cannot capture if council members are facilitating greater access to other stages in helping citizens access the justice system. Nevertheless, by considering only the cases that escalate into formal proceedings serves as a hard test of the theory that seeks to understand access to the formal justice system.

This data concerns Maharashtra’s lower judiciary scraped from the state’s public-facing website.⁹ The case-level metadata in Maharashtra includes the location from where the complaint originated—for rural areas, this is a census village from the 2001 census. Earlier work using such data for all of India indicates that the data is reliable between 2010 and 2018 (Ash et al. 2025; M. Rao 2024). I expect the data to have been regularly updated, given that Maharashtra is a state with higher state capacity compared to other states in India. The cases are classified into whether they are civil cases or criminal cases using a simple case coding rule elaborated in Appendix Section 1.6. Using the case level data, I create a panel dataset of village-year observations, with outcomes that include counts of all case filings, civil filings and criminal filings between 2016 and 2022.

I restrict the main analysis to a subset of cases in which all parties associated with a case have their addresses in the same village, and the case is filed at the level of Civil Judge Junior Division, Civil Judge Senior Division or Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class at the sub-district level.¹⁰ In Appendix Section 4.5, I show robustness to including cases filed from multiple villages using a Regression Discontinuity Aggregation (RDA) design at the sub-district level. I collected 3.37 million cases that were filed in the lower courts, and restricting to cases whose parties originated from a single village, I am able to analyze 1.2 million cases which make up 35% of total cases filed

⁹District Courts, Maharashtra https://court.mah.nic.in/courtweb/index_eng.php#, Last Accessed in December 2023 after which the data (without the village-level identifiers) can be accessed from the national eCourts repository.

¹⁰I make these restrictions for two reasons: first, I expect my theory to apply to disputes where all parties are from the same village, given that council members would be less likely to expend time and effort on issues that they may not be able to claim credit for. Second, cases that arise from multiple villages cannot be assigned as outcomes given that (1) the treatment village cannot be determined for such cases and (2) using such outcomes would violate the SUTVA assumption. I focus on subordinate courts that have unique jurisdictions that cover particular villages. Cases that are filed in subordinate courts do not involve large sums of money or long sentences. For additional details on limiting the analysis to subordinate courts, see Appendix Section 1.7. The village of the party is determined by the address of the plaintiff and defendant filed in the system—these can be individuals or organizations. For criminal cases, if there are three accused, the addresses of all three will be entered in the system. Although the state is a “party” to the case, an address for the state is not entered in this case.

within this period.

Village Councils: The number of members in each council depends on the population of the jurisdiction of the village council. Typically, a village council is constituted for a single revenue village; however, some councils span over two or three villages. I collect data on councils and villages from the Local Government Directory—a dataset that defines unique land region boundaries for rural local governments that map on to India’s census data. The government maintains this dataset as an “up-to-date list of respective administrative units”. I use this data to list over 28,000 village councils in Maharashtra, and merge it with other datasets like *MahaEgram*, that allows me to focus on subsets of councils that are created before 2016. A map of all councils in Maharashtra, and the number of members in each council is shown in Figure 3 in Appendix Section 1.4. I further link this data to the Socioeconomic High-resolution Rural-Urban Geographic Platform for India (or SHRUG) using village census identifiers. This allows me augment the data with information from the 2011 census with council demographics and characteristics like education and income levels, availability of transport, infrastructure, and other variables.

Council Elections Data: I collected data on elections conducted in each council from the State Election Commission’s website. This contains important information on candidates, winners, winning margins and turnout. The earliest election recorded on the website is from 2017, and data were scraped up to the 2022 elections. I further assemble data on council characteristics (date of establishment, area, facilities etc.) from *MahaEgram*, a data repository of village councils managed by the Rural Development and Panchayat Raj Department of the Government of Maharashtra. Additionally, I use the data on the profiles of local elected representatives from the Maharashtra State Election Commission for elections held in 2021 to test mechanisms.

Survey Data: To explore possible mechanisms, I rely on data from the National Council of Applied Economics Rural Economic and Demographic Survey (REDS).¹¹ The survey collects data from a nationally representative sample of over 8,659 households in 240 rural villages in 17 Indian states.

¹¹Data has been generously shared by Andrew Foster.

4.2 Empirical Strategy

In this section, I focus on the empirical strategy to test H_1 , that pertains to whether increasing the number of elected representatives increases access to the formal justice system. A challenge to testing whether adding additional elected members to a village council affects access to justice is that villages with more members in a council may be different from those that have fewer members in the council due to omitted unobservables. For example, villages with a greater number of members may be more populated, closer to courts, have more educated residents, and differ in their social culture. These differences in council characteristics can, in turn, affect whether aggrieved parties approach the courts. Therefore, a simple comparison between smaller and larger councils could result in bias.

To study this systematically, I would need to look at a case where there is a different number of elected members assigned to “similar” areas. To do so, I leverage the population-based cut-off that determines the number of elected council members in the villages of Maharashtra using a regression discontinuity (RD) design.

Maharashtra is a large state in the western part of India with a population of 112 million, and is divided into 36 administrative districts. Each district is divided into sub-districts (*Talukas*), which are further divided into 28,000 village councils or *Gram Panchayats*.

The system to determine the number of local elected representatives to form a village council varies across Indian states. Regarding the composition of the councils, the 73rd Constitution Amendment in 1992, which mandated the creation of village councils, was ambiguous: the Act mentions that the “ratio between the population of the territorial area of a Panchayat at any level and the number of seats in such Panchayat to be filled by election shall. . . be the same throughout the State”.¹², leaving the specifics up to individual states. Thus, there is heterogeneity in the size of a village council in each state: the number of council members in Kerala is between 13 and 23 members, while in Karnataka and Bihar, the number of members is determined by a population-based rule.¹³ Similarly, in Uttar Pradesh, the rule is determined by population cut-offs (Narasimhan and Weaver 2023)—a Panchayat area having a population of 1000 gets 9 members, 1000-2000 gets 11 members,

¹²Constitution of India, 73rd Amendment, <https://www.india.gov.in/my-government/constitution-india/amendments/constitution-india-seventy-third-amendment-act-1992>

¹³For every 400 (Karnataka) and 500 (Bihar) persons, there is one elected member—see <http://bit.ly/karnataka-rule> and <http://bit.ly/bihar-rule> respectively.

Table 1: Village Council Population based cutoffs for number of members.

Village Council Population Thresholds	Number Of Council Members
<1500	7
1501-3000	9
3001-4500	11
4501-6000	13
6001-7500	15
>7501	17

Source: Maharashtra Village Panchayat Act, 1959. Population thresholds to be based strictly on previous census conducted.

2000-3000 gets 13 members and more than 3000 gets 15 members.

In this paper, I exploit a version of this rule in Maharashtra, which was one of the few states with effective councils and regular elections before the 73rd Amendment (Chaudhary and Iyer 2022). Moreover, it has one of the highest rankings regarding actual devolution of power to the councils (Unnikrishnan 2016). Elections involved electing the *pradhan* (head) and the members of the *Gram Panchayat*, and in recent years, they have been conducted both by direct election by the citizens, as well as through indirect elections (wherein the village head is elected indirectly among the elected members) (Heinze 2025).

In Maharashtra, the size of the local council is based on population cutoffs, which motivates a regression discontinuity (RD) design. The RD design exploits the continuity in the running variable—that is, the population of the council and the discontinuity at the cutoff between being assigned a smaller or larger council size. As per the Maharashtra Village Panchayat Act of 1959, the number of council members is determined by population cut-offs which I tabulate in Table 1. Here, we see that at a threshold of 1500, villages above the threshold have 9 elected members who form the village council, while those with a population below the threshold have 7 elected members that form the village council.

For councils with populations close to the threshold, the treatment (addition of two council members) can be assumed to be as-if randomly assigned. This is the first time this research design is being used in the Indian context; however, a related research design has been used in a different context by Mignozzetti, Cepaluni, and Freire (2024), where the authors study the effects of legislature size on

public service provision in Brazil.

Given the multiple cut-offs, I can either normalize and pool the results to form a single cutoff, or estimate effects at each cutoff using a multi-cutoff regression discontinuity design (Cattaneo, Keele, Rocío Titiunik, et al. 2016). The multiple cut-offs can help overcome a common shortcoming of regression-discontinuity methods in estimating causal effects—with just a single cutoff, we do not know if the treatment effect persists for those units whose scores on the ‘running variable’ are farther away from the cut-off (Cattaneo, Keele, Roc’io Titiunik, et al. 2021).

While a design with multiple cutoffs can circumvent this issue, it is important to establish that the estimates are not contaminated by multiple treatments, which can be a common feature of regression discontinuity designs. Indeed, population thresholds can affect not only the size of councils, but also eligibility for public programs (Asher and Novosad 2020) as well as electoral systems in play (Arora 2022). I systematically searched for government programs that would contaminate any of the five cutoffs shown in Table 1. While no such programs appear to use the 1500, 4500, 6000 and 7500 cutoffs, a cutoff of 3000 is being used to determine eligibility for several schemes and I therefore remove it from further analyses. Further, other cutoffs at 4500, 6000 and 7500 not only change the size of the council, but also determine the number and size of wards within the council territory. I choose to fix the treatment as the addition of two council members at the first cutoff¹⁴ that includes council sizes exposed to the first cutoff with populations between 750 and 2250¹⁵. I leverage a sharp regression discontinuity design using council population as the running variable, since the population determines the number of seats in each council.¹⁶

I define causal effects in the potential outcomes setup as follows: $Y_i(0)$ and $Y_i(1)$ are the number of cases filed from council i where $Y_i(0)$ is the measure of cases on the left of the threshold (the control condition) and $Y_i(1)$ is the measure of cases to the right of the threshold (the treatment condition). The population of the council is denoted by X_i . The causal effect of an increase in council size by two members can be given as $Y_i(1) - Y_i(0)$. However, since both cannot be observed at the same time for individual councils, we can compute the average treatment effect exactly at the cutoff c as follows:

¹⁴Information on heterogeneity at each cutoff is provided in Appendix Sections 2.1 and 2.2.

¹⁵Based on the mid-point between the first and second cutoff.

¹⁶For a test of compliance, see Appendix Section 2.5.

$$\tau = \mathbb{E}[Y_i(1) - Y_i(0)|X_i = c] = \mathbb{E}[Y_i(1)|X_i = c] - \mathbb{E}[Y_i(0)|X_i = c] \quad (1)$$

The key identifying assumption is that $\mathbb{E}[Y_i(1)|X_i = c]$ and $\mathbb{E}[Y_i(0)|X_i = c]$ are continuous in X_i , which ensures that all unobserved variables and confounders are also continuous in X_i . This allows us to use the observations to the left of the cutoff as counterfactuals for the observations to the right of the cutoff. I collect cases for each village v that is nested within a council i , over eight years, with each year denoted by t ¹⁷. In Appendix Section 1.1, I visually show the trends over time. The jurisdiction of each council can comprise of one or more villages (for a spatial distribution, refer to Appendix Section 1.2). Thus, my preferred specification is to capture the different levels and the temporal aspect of the data, by clustering the errors at the council-year level as follows:

$$Y_{vit} = \tau D_i + f(X_i) + \epsilon_{it} \quad (2)$$

Where Y_i is the outcome for village v in council i in year t , D_i is an indicator for the treatment (defined as the addition of two council members), ϵ_i is the error term, $f(x)$ is a polynomial function of the running variable—typically either linear, quadratic, cubic or quartic, and τ gives us the average treatment effect at the cutoff.

The treatment effect τ can be estimated using non-parametric techniques within a narrow bandwidth on each side of the cutoff. In my preferred specification, I use linear regression equations on either side of the cutoff, with a triangular kernel (wherein observations close to the cutoff have greater weights) and I use the mean-squared error (MSE) approach to choose bandwidths to obtain the local average treatment effect (LATE), or τ .

¹⁷Although I have data over time that could have allowed me to leverage a difference-in-discontinuities design, note that the treatment is assigned in the year of the census (2011) and the case-level data I collect is all from the period after the census is conducted, that is, between 2015 and 2023. Thus, a difference-in-discontinuities is not applicable in this scenario

4.3 Key Assumptions of Identification

As discussed above, the key identification assumption in a regression continuity design is that the outcomes for the treated and untreated units are continuous in X_i around the threshold $X_i = c$ where X_i is the running variable and c denotes the cutoff. This gives us the ability to estimate the treatment effect.

While the identification assumption is fundamentally untestable, we can increase the credibility of the regression discontinuity design using the following approaches.

Continuity in Running Variable: First, I conduct a density discontinuity test. This helps us assess whether individuals in councils can manipulate the running variable X_i —that is, the population in our case. Manipulation in this case would imply sorting: the concern is that a local council can select into either side of the discontinuity through corruption, perhaps because smaller councils can help local elites secure their power and positions by falsifying the population numbers. In such a scenario, the population distribution across villages will not be smooth.

We can assess whether there are distributional imbalances in the running variable on either side of the cutoff. I run the Cattaneo, Jansson, and Ma (2020), using local polynomials ranging from the first to fourth order. The null hypothesis implies that there is no manipulation. For each order, the p-values are as follows: local linear (0.66), quadratic (0.49), cubic (0.42) and quartic (0.21). This implies that we have no evidence of manipulation. The test is visually shown in the Appendix Figure A4.

Continuity in Observable Characteristics: Second, the identification implies that influences on other council characteristics are also continuous in X at $X = c$. If the measures of pre-treatment covariates are not balanced across the control and treatment group, they might confound the estimates of the treatment. I test this by analyzing the means for larger and smaller council sizes in Table 2 below for a range of outcomes within a constant bandwidth.

For the analysis in Table 2, I first assemble a list of pre-treatment covariates that could be possible confounds—any imbalances on these may imply that the estimated treatment effects are due to other confounding factors, and not simply due to the increase in council size. We see that the p-values for all are greater than 0.05 thus we fail to reject the hypothesis that they are statistically distinguishable.

Table 2: Tests of Covariate Balance

Covariates	Units	Control	Treatment	<i>p-val</i>
All weather road	1/0	0.67	0.67	0.82
Public transport available	1/0	0.84	0.85	0.64
Internal road	1/0	0.37	0.36	0.63
Distance from HQ	km.	55.62	54.88	0.42
Graduates+	%	0.03	0.03	0.24
Distance to Court	km.	26.66	25.79	0.42
Distance to Police Station	km.	9.65	10.18	0.12
High income (INR 5000+)	%	22.90	23.01	0.82
High income (INR 10000+)	%	6.87	7.15	0.23

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. I take the means of observations within a bandwidth of 300 below and above the cutoff. The units column indicates the units of a measure: they can be either be for binary (roads, public transport availability) or continuous (distance, land, number of graduates, shares) variables. All variables are measured based on data from the 2011 census or the 2011 socio-economic caste census, as compiled in the ‘SHRUG’ dataset. ‘p-val’ indicates the p-value from two sided t-test. The treatment is regressed on the jurisdiction’s characteristics to conduct a joint hypothesis test, which imposes restrictions on multiple coefficients. I fail to reject the null hypothesis that the coefficients of the predictors are jointly 0, given a p-value of 0.49 associated with an F-statistic of 0.92

In the Appendix Figure A5, I show graphically that variables like connectivity (roads, availability of transport), geographic characteristics (distance to district headquarters, courts and police station) and socio-economic factors (education, income) are similar in treated and control villages (on either side of the cutoff).

5 Results

To test my theory, I present three sets of empirical results. I use a sharp regression discontinuity design as evidence to show that increasing council size increases access to justice, for both criminal and civil cases (H_1). I leverage the same design and show that additional council members do not influence court processes. Finally I present evidence from qualitative evidence that describes how council members serve as intermediaries.

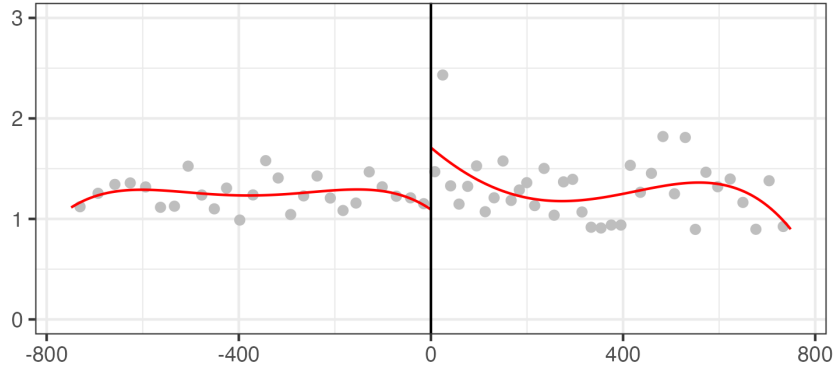
5.1 Representatives increase access to the justice system

I present the results of the main analysis, that leverages the regression discontinuity design. I start by describing the standard regression discontinuity plots for the three outcomes: all cases, criminal

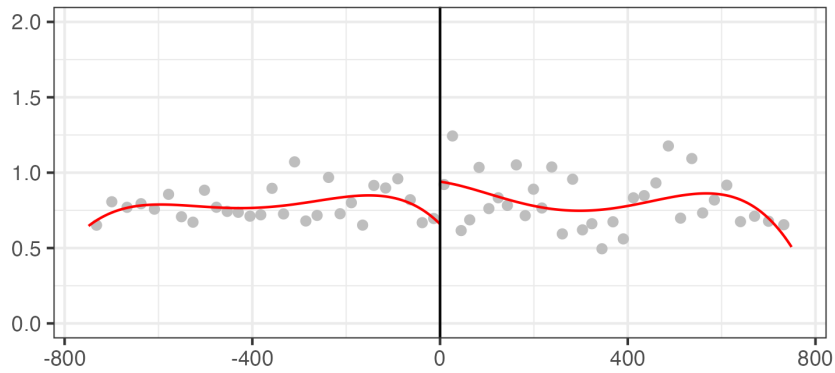
cases and civil cases.

Figure 1: Regression discontinuity plots by case type

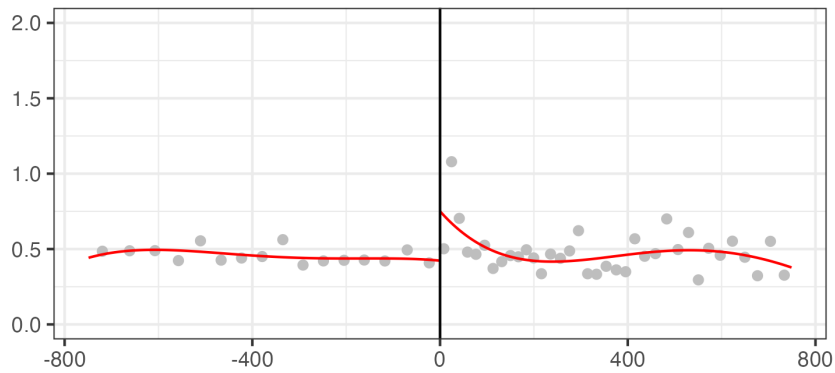
All Cases



Criminal Cases



Civil Cases



Notes: X-axis plots the centered running variable (council population). Each grey dot in the figure represents a count of cases per 1000 residents for each village-year combination, based on quantile-spaced binning (Calonico et al. 2019). Red lines denote local polynomial regressions of order four.

While the plots themselves are not a formal test, they provide descriptive evidence along with

visualizations of the global trend. We can see from Figure A4 that for each of the outcomes, there is an increase in cases filed to the right of the threshold, relative to the left. Importantly, there is an upward break for each of the outcomes at the cutoff—suggestive of the fact that increasing council size can increase the number of cases filed with the formal legal system.

I now turn to a formal test of this relationship. I report local linear regression discontinuity estimates using Calonico, Cattaneo, and Rocio Titiunik (2014) optimal bandwidth and triangular kernels, with robust standard errors clustered at the council-year level in parentheses with a polynomial of degree one.

Table 3 displays the results without controls. Each regression result shows the total number of observations, the effective number of observations below and above the cutoff, the estimated local average treatment effect τ and the robust bias-corrected p values.

From the results in Table 3, we are able to confirm the positive effect of council size on access to the formal legal system as illustrated in the plots. Approximately 1 case per 1000 residents gets filed in a court from a village with a smaller council size each year. The results imply that increasing the size of the council by two members leads to a 51% increase in the number of cases filed. To assess the magnitude of the effect, I calculate the standardized mean difference (*Cohen's d*), wherein I use the standard deviation of the control group within the bandwidth. I find that the treatment results in an effect size of 0.17 standard deviation, suggesting a small-to-medium sized impact.

The results are consistent when I classify cases into criminal and civil cases. An increase in council size leads to a 48% increase in criminal case filings, and 62% for civil case filings. These results provide support H_1 —that increasing council size can increase access to the formal legal system.

In the Appendix Section 4.1, 4.2 and 4.3, I show that these results are robust to changes in bandwidth, district characteristics and functional form of the models used. The results are also robust to analyzing only the newly-formed councils as a natural experiment—see Appendix Section 4.5 and Table A11 for discussion and results, however these results are no longer statistically significant. Finally, I do not observe any statistically significant effects when analysing the outcomes using placebo cutoffs at half the cutoff values, as seen in Appendix Table A10.

Next, I test if additional council members affect court processes. While the previous section shows

Table 3: Council Members Increase Access to the Justice System

	All Cases	Criminal Cases	Civil Cases
LATE	0.58** (0.24)	0.32* (0.17)	0.27** (0.11)
Obs. (L)	57281	57281	57281
Obs. (R)	44414	44414	44414
Effective Obs. (L)	15440	13240	19866
Effective Obs. (R)	13957	12041	17644
Bandwidth	197	171	251
Bandwidth (Bias)	336	302	391

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Robust standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council level. The treatment is councils with two additional members. Each observation is cases measured from a village in a particular year. Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. Bandwidth is in number of persons.

that the addition of two council members to the local body can increase case filings, I argue that they cannot meaningfully influence processes once the cases reach the courts. This is primarily due to two reasons: first, that the legal branch is sufficiently separated and insulated from the legislative branch, and second, that courts are extremely overburdened and slow due to a number of institutional reasons (Bhavnani, Bhogale, and Jadhav 2025) which hard to fix for individual cases, and to be influenced by village council members.

I test this using the case level data, which allows me to calculate the number of decisions issued for each village, and if decided, the average time (in days) that the case was decided in, using the filing and decision dates for each case. We confirm these expectations in Table 4: the additional council members are not able to meaningfully influence court processes. Even though litigants from villages file a greater number of cases, courts do not issue a larger number of decisions, or resolve the cases quickly. This has two implications—first, the influence of council members is limited to making a bridge to the legal institutions possible, and second, that the working quality of the courts does not diminish on account of being inundated by additional case filings.

Table 4: Politicians do not affect court processes

	Decisions	Time to Decision
LATE	0.12 (0.10)	-6.58 (26.61)
Obs. (L)	88568	8390
Obs. (R)	48624	5810
Effective Obs. (L)	30456	3349
Effective Obs. (R)	25576	3120
Bandwidth	309	329
Bandwidth (Bias)	524	497

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Robust standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council-year level. The treatment is councils with two additional members. Each observation is number of decisions and the mean time to decision for cases measured from a village in a particular year. Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. Bandwidth is in number of persons. Note that the fewer number of observations for the time to decision outcome is due to the fact that it can only be measured if a decision is issued for a case filed from the council in a particular year.

5.2 Council Members as Intermediaries

I draw on qualitative data and shadowing to highlight the ways in which these council members act as intermediaries. I use two sources of qualitative data. First, I use data from anonymized field notes collected by research assistants from Bussell (2020b). Fourteen village council presidents were ‘shadowed’ (Bussell 2020a) for approximately two days, as they carried out their regular daily activities. Bussell (2020a) explains: ‘this method allows for detailed descriptions of president’s behaviors and interactions’, and shares detailed notes on her website. Second, I analyze qualitative data from phone interviews with 19 council members currently serving in village councils across Maharashtra.

Out of the fourteen presidents shadowed, 6 of them engaged in some activity pertaining to the police. These instances provide evidence of direct interactions with the police, where the council president assists with case filing. I reproduce the evidence from the field notes during the shadowing of council president D: “Council president D was approached for help in filing an FIR for a stolen television set. The president calls the head constable, requesting to file an FIR”. During the shadowing of council president G, the notes share this instance: “Council president G was approached by a woman with whom the school headmaster had misbehaved, and the president helped the woman by helping her

write an application to the senior police officer”. Finally, during the shadowing of council president J, we see a similar incident: “Council president J called the police officer in charge to investigate a case of a woman from the village who had been harassed by a man”.

These instances highlight the fact that the council president has been approached for help with registering a complaint at the police station. I further conduct informational interviews with 19 council members, inquiring their perceptions on the role they play in dispute resolution. The short informational interviews focused on the role played by council members when their constituents experience disputes (see Appendix Section 5.2 for the questionnaire). I first inquired what role they play in dispute resolution, provided them with hypothetical scenarios of a civil dispute within a family involving land and inheritance, and a criminal issue wherein a murder had been committed. A limitation of this question was that in many villages, crimes like murders are rare, so few members had experience with such a grave crime. Nonetheless, the question elicited responses regarding how they would deal with grave crimes that would take place in the village. I reproduce a number of quotes and excerpts that provide suggestive evidence of the role played by council members in disputes.

I asked council members about the differences in handling civil and criminal disputes. Most respondents agreed that most small disputes get resolved within the village itself and there is no requirement to involve external authorities. When prompted to elaborate on these differences, one president said, “Typically, the *police patil*¹⁸ and *sarpanch*¹⁹ will try to solve the dispute at the village level itself. Only in the case of a big crime, the police will get involved”. Another council member remarked: “If it is a major crime, it will go to the police station and the courts. Criminal cases cannot be resolved within the village”. This confirms the dual role played by politicians in dispute resolution: one is in local dispute resolution, and the other is in helping litigants access the formal legal institutions.

Second, I asked council members about the interactions they have had with the police, and to describe

¹⁸The Maharashtra Gazette explains that the “police patil” is a village level official, subordinate to the Police Sub-Inspector of the area concerned. They are responsible for the maintenance of peace and order in the village, and is expected to assist the Police in investigating the crimes. Details reproduced from the Maharashtra Gazette at <http://bit.ly/409iuDb> accessed on July 10, 2025.

¹⁹The head of the elected council.

the circumstances. One council member proudly shared that he knows the *beat hawaldhar*.²⁰ Another member shared: “If there is any issue in the village, or a case is registered from the village, the police will call the *gram panchayat* member, and we try to see if we can resolve the issue at the village level itself, since it will be a cheaper resolution”. A village president shared: “In case of any investigation in the village, the police get in touch with police patil, sarpanch and *gram panchayat* member”. These interviews highlight the forms of interactions and instances wherein the officers of the law enforcement system are closely knit with elected council members, and thus council members are equipped with the know-how on how they can help their constituents file complaints and approach courts.

6 Mechanism: Capacity and descriptive representation

In this section I show that that additional human resources available in the village council increases its capacity to do work and help constituents with their disputes (H_2). Further, I test whether larger councils improve descriptive representation of non-dominant groups (H_3). I show that larger councils increases the representation of non-dominant groups, partly driven by affirmative action or “quotas”, and further that this increases case filings for litigants from such groups. I rule out mechanisms related to changes in the electoral context in Appendix Section 3.2.

6.1 Increase in Capacity

Increasing the size of the council mechanically generates two changes: it decreases political jurisdictions and consequently, increases the representative to citizen ratio. This can make citizens feel closer to decision makers, making them more approachable and efficacious: studies on changes in jurisdictional size have demonstrated that larger jurisdictions have a detrimental effect on citizens’ internal political efficacy and satisfaction (Hansen 2015; Lassen and Serritzlew 2011).

In the context of Maharashtra, at the first cutoff, we see that the number of representatives per citizen goes from one for 214 citizens to one for 166 citizens: a decrease in the number of citizens per politicians but an increase in the ratio of politicians to citizens by 28%. I argue that this increase in

²⁰The *beat hawaldhar* is the constables in-charge of the village, usually placed at the police headquarters.

the representatives to citizen ratio is the main mechanism that is driving the results. Increasing the number of politicians per constituent increases the human resources available to provide assistance. As has been shown before across political institutions, increasing the number of public officials in India—across bureaucracies (Muralidharan and Sundararaman 2013) and judiciaries (M. Rao 2024)—improves the performance of institutions in obtaining their goals. We might expect similar benefits as we increase the size (capacity) of local governments, given our contextual knowledge that tells us that local officials are overloaded with work (Dasgupta and Kapur 2020), and that local elections are frequent and competitive (Auerbach and Ziegfeld 2020)—making shirking and free-riding of politicians less likely.

A qualitative coding of the field notes collected by Bussell (2020a) reveals that council leaders spend between four and eight hours each day on various activities—including but not limited to—resolving issues, speaking with villagers and visiting government offices. Given that this work is both demanding in terms of time and resources, and is unpaid, the additional resources can make a sizable difference on the conduct of such work.

An alternative argument is that a larger body leads to more shirking, increasing the free-rider problem. However, this seems unlikely given the context of Indian elections, wherein members have clear responsibilities (Bhavnani 2021). Moreover, local politicians in India face competitive elections and seek re-elections to the same or higher office, and especially given the fact that elections to councils having a larger size bring about 13% additional voters to turnout during elections (Appendix Table A9). Neglecting duties might hurt a member's reputation, winning chances and trust at the local level. If representatives are aware of this payoff, they would be most responsive as elections approach. I test for electoral cycles and show evidence of this in Appendix Table A6.

Further, I leverage survey data to test the observable implications of increasing the human resources available for constituency service and show that the additional work performed by council members benefits them through reputational gains and increases capacity to solve local issues. To empirically test this, I use data from the National Council of Applied Economics Rural Economic and Demographic Survey (REDS). This section analyzes the 2006-08 round of the nationally representative survey, which covers more than 8,000 rural households across India. I focus my analysis on more than 88,000 respondents from 233 villages in India, taking advantage of the fact that

larger councils are allotted to villages between two elections, typically when they cross a population threshold.

The survey asks each respondent to rate the current and previous village council members. Each respondent is asked to rate council members' honesty and qualifications, and rate how well council members solve social and local problems. Responses are based on an ordinal scale (High = 1, Medium = 2, Low = 3, Not aware = 4). I exclude respondents who answered they were not aware to answer about the quality and ability of council members, and recode the outcomes based on an increasing score of evaluation for ease of interpretation. See Appendix Section 5.1 for the exact questions used in the survey.

I analyse the survey data with a difference-in-differences design, since ratings are collected for both the current and previous village council. Of the 233 villages, 64 villages are assigned a larger council in the current period, as compared to a previous period.

Thus, I can run a specification of the following:

$$Y_{it} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \cdot \text{Post}_t + \beta_2 \cdot \text{Treat}_v + \beta_3 \cdot (\text{Post}_{it} \times \text{Treat}_v) + X_i + \epsilon_v \quad (3)$$

Here, Y_{it} represents the outcome for respondent i from village v at time t , Treat_v is an indicator that takes the value 1 if the respondent is in a treated village, Post_{it} takes the value 1 if the individual is evaluating the ratings for the current council, and 0 if the evaluation is for the previous council. X_i includes respondent level controls: sex, religion, years of schooling and caste. Standard errors are clustered at the village level.

I find in Table 5 that on being assigned to a larger council causes respondents to increase their rating on a host of measures of quality and ability of council members—we see that the coefficients are positive for all outcomes, and statistically significant for two of them: respondents hold better perceptions of council member's qualifications, wherein the treatment causes 3.6% increase in the outcome relative to baseline. Further, we see that respondents increase their evaluations of council member's ability: the treatment causes a 3% increase in their perceptions of a council

member’s ability to solve local problems relative to the baseline. An important caveat of this design is that responses have been collected at a single period, and respondent’s ratings of previous council members could be biased when they receive the treatment: the recall bias may differ between the treatment and control groups. As such, these results provide suggestive evidence of an increase in council member’s ability to provide constituency service by responding to local disputes.²¹

Table 5: Effect of Larger Council on Quality and Ability of Council Members

	Beneficiary Fairness	Qualifications	Solve social problems	Solve local problems
ATT	0.03 (0.03)	0.06* (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)	0.06** (0.03)
Observations	88,980	83,416	86,102	88,673
Adjusted R ²	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.01

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the village level. The treatment is council population crosses population threshold which assigns two additional seats. Each observation takes an ordinal outcome taking values between 1 and 3, with 3 being the highest rating. ‘Honesty’ is a rating of the council member’s honesty and fairness. ‘Qualifications’ is a rating of the council member’s technical qualifications. ‘Solve social problems’ is a rating of the council member’s ability to solve social problems, such as disputes over land, marriage etc. ‘Solve local problems’ is a rating of the council member’s ability to solve local problems such as roads, education, water etc.

6.2 Increase in Descriptive Representation

Another reason that could explain the increase in legal mobilization from villages with larger councils is that a larger council increases representation of non-dominant groups, by decreasing the costs of running for election. I use the data on the profiles of local elected representatives—particularly data from the Maharashtra State Election Commission for elections held in 2021 that includes the gender and caste of all candidates.²² There were 15003 election contests held in 2021, and I am able to correctly match the names of the council elections for 90% (13629 out of 15003) of councils to the census data. I use the same sharp RD design to test whether the size of the legislature affects the number of representatives for elected who are female or belong to historically marginalized groups (namely, members from the scheduled castes and scheduled tribes). 8055 councils are within the

²¹While it is possible to overcome these issues by looking at the *Socio Economic Profile of Rural Households in India (SEPRI) - 2014* survey, this was a shorter follow-up to the REDS and the same questions were not asked.

²²This data was collected by Priyadarshi Amar during his dissertation fieldwork (Amar 2025a) and I sincerely thank him for sharing the same.

population range for the cutoff at 1500 which I analyse below. Note that these data only include the seats that were “contested”—that is, the election was actually conducted, and exclude seats where no election was conducted since candidates were elected unopposed.

Representation of women, SC and ST members is also shaped by quotas. In these village councils, 50% of seats are reserved for women, and consequently 50% of additional seats are also reserved for women. Quotas for SC and ST members are based on their respective shares in the council population. I test whether a larger council size increases descriptive representation, above and beyond those driven by these quotas, by calculating the representation of each group that is not accounted for by quotas. That is, for each council, I subtract the number of quota seats held by members of group i from the number of total seats held by members of group i .

In Table 6, we see that there are meaningful spillovers or ‘overflow’ of mandated quotas: leading to an increase in representation of female and SC members in the village council. This is in line with previous work that finds that quotas can affect representation beyond their target dimension (Amar 2025a; Karekurve-Ramachandra and Lee 2020).

What explains the increase in representation? While the theoretical underpinnings of a more representative council suggested that elections to larger councils might reduce the barriers to entry, I show in Appendix Table A9 that this is not the case: for each seat in a larger council, I do not find any change in the competitiveness of the election or the number of candidates contesting for elections at each seat. However, elections to a larger council increase the turnout by over 12%, indicating greater political mobilization in jurisdictions with a larger council size, pointing to a change in the types of candidates who are contesting.

Is such an increase in representation consequential? My data allows me to test this by looking at civil cases. I classifying cases that based on the demographic characteristics of litigants for civil cases. I classify the names mentioned in the case records by using machine-learning based approaches. These approaches use a combination of methods—a neural network trained on name patterns relying on millions of names in the Indian Electoral Rolls to predict gender (Laohaprapanon, Sood, and Chintalapati 2026), a Bayes classifier based on 140 million names in the Socio-Economic Caste Census of India to predict caste (Laohaprapanon and Sood 2026) and a neural network based classifier trained on names in the Bihar Land Records data to predict religion (Chintalapati, Dar,

Table 6: Council Size and Representation of Non-Dominant Groups

	Additional Female Members	Additional SC Members	Additional ST Members
LATE	0.17*** (0.06)	0.05* (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)
Obs. (L)	4669	4669	4669
Obs. (R)	3386	3386	3386
Effective Obs. (L)	1619	1383	1179
Effective Obs. (R)	1365	1207	1068
Bandwidth	258	223	194
Bandwidth (Bias)	442	339	306

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Robust standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council level. The treatment is councils with two additional members. Each observation is number of additional council members for each group i , given by $M_i - R_i$, wherein M_i denotes members elected from group i and R_i denotes seats reserved for group i . Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. Bandwidth is in number of persons.

and Sood 2025). Note that these names are of the litigants for civil cases, and of the defendants for criminal cases.

I use this information to see whether the increase in council size can change the characteristics of litigants approaching the justice system for civil cases. From Table 7, we see an increase in cases that have atleast one female litigant from councils with additional members. While there is also substantially large increase in the number of cases filed by litigants belonging to marginalized groups and minorities, these results are not statistically significant. This provides some evidence that the increase in accessing courts is partly driven by increased litigation from diverse groups.

The results shown so far paint an optimistic picture about the role played by council members in lowering barriers. These findings could also underscore a more pessimistic story: one where council members use their ties with the state to prosecute members from non-dominant groups. This might be due to a backlash effect or a capture of the local state apparatus, where additional council members allow dominant interests to better coordinate with law enforcement. To test this, I use the same machine-learning based approach to examine the demographic profile of defendants in criminal cases. If the increase in legal activity were driven by state-led repression, we would expect to see a disproportionate increase in criminal prosecutions against marginalized groups in

Table 7: Increase in council size changes characteristics of litigants

	>=1 Female Litigant	>=1 Litigant from Marginalized Group	>=1 Litigant from Minority
LATE	0.17* (0.09)	0.40 (0.31)	0.40 (0.31)
Obs. (L)	57512	57512	57512
Obs. (R)	44590	44590	44590
Effective Obs. (L)	8967	15085	15085
Effective Obs. (R)	8358	13664	13664
Bandwidth	117	192	192
Bandwidth (Bias)	227	296	296

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Robust standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council level. The treatment is councils with two additional members. Each observation is cases measured from a village in a particular year. Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. Bandwidth is in number of persons.

jurisdictions with larger councils. However, in Table 8 I show that there is no statistically significant increase in the prosecution of members from non-dominant groups. This finding supports the theory and qualitative evidence presented so far that the increase in court access is a function of genuine legal mobilization, rather than an expansion of the state's carceral reach at the behest of local elites.

Table 8: Increase in council size does not lead to identity-based prosecutions

	>=1 Female Accused	>=1 Accused from Marginalized Group	>=1 Accused from Minority
LATE	0.09 (0.05)	0.05 (0.08)	0.13 (0.09)
Obs. (L)	57512	57512	57512
Obs. (R)	44590	44590	44590
Effective Obs. (L)	9275	13524	11620
Effective Obs. (R)	8624	12313	10507
Bandwidth	120	174	150
Bandwidth (Bias)	223	300	303

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Robust standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council level. The treatment is councils with two additional members. Each observation is cases measured from a village in a particular year. Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. Bandwidth is in number of persons.

7 Conclusion

The United Nations defines access to justice as a fundamental principle of the rule of law—without which people cannot exercise their rights, challenge discrimination or hold decision-makers accountable. Access to justice is the principle that allows individuals to seek effective and substantive resolutions of their legal issues through a legal system that is fair and equitable. A strong legal system improves entrepreneurship (Chemin 2009), security of property rights (Abera and Chemin 2021), and firm productivity (M. Rao 2024).

These results show that representatives serve as a critical bridge to formalize both civil and criminal claims that require the state’s investigative authority.

Studying access to justice poses challenges for researchers, since there are many determinants of why individuals approach legal authorities, and isolating the role of a particular determinant is difficult without a robust research design. Second, since instances of disputes are not experienced by everyone in the population, researchers find it difficult to measure access to justice through surveys. A major innovation of this study is to answer this question using a credible regression discontinuity design, interviews and micro-level data on court cases.

In this paper, I demonstrate that members of village councils can improve access to justice for rural citizens—particularly for criminal cases—almost doubling the number of criminal cases that end up being litigated in the formal legal system. This enables individuals to enforce their rights through the formal legal system, which can prevent power abuse and promote equality and human development.

Councils with greater size improve access to justice through greater descriptive representation, as these councils elect a greater number of members from non-dominant groups. This increase in representation can make them more effective as it allows the elected body to provide help and provide assistance to diverse members of the village community. Suggestive evidence also suggests that such bodies are also perceived to be of greater quality and ability.

In doing so, this paper makes important contributions to the literature on access to justice and legal mobilization (Black 1973; Galanter 2010; Genn 1999; J. Krishnan et al. 2014; Sandefur 2008). While prior literature discusses the role of village-level authorities in dispute resolution, my research reveals a new dimension: I find that elected members of local governments help constituents access

formal legal institutions, which is essential to strengthening the rule of law, preventing conflict, and supporting economic development. Rather than substituting for a weak formal legal system, politicians play a complementary role, channeling cases towards the courts.

Second, this paper brings together the literature on constituency service and council and legislature size. Increasing the number of politicians may have mixed effects on public services (Mignozzetti, Cepaluni, and Freire 2024), finances (Freire et al. 2023) and overall development (De Santo and Le Maux 2023). This paper shows that larger councils can increase the overall capacity of the body by having a greater number of individual politicians engaged in constituency service. Studying this additional dimension—whether the number of politicians affects behaviors linked to constituency service—can form the basis of a promising research agenda, evaluating the effects of larger councils on responsiveness, trust and accountability.

Several governments in developing countries began a process of decentralizing development planning and management in the 1970s, to increase responsiveness and improve local development (Bardhan 2002). A key aspect of the decentralization process has been the formation smaller political units that elect a number of local representatives, creating local bodies for urban and rural areas. Such local bodies are not unique to India, and span countries across the world like Indonesia, Brazil, Uganda, China, South Africa, Pakistan and Bolivia (Bardhan and Mookherjee 2006). By demonstrating how members of these local bodies facilitate access to justice, I contribute to the larger comparative literature on local politics and decentralization.

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Appendix: The Political Roots of Legal Access: Evidence from Village Councils in India

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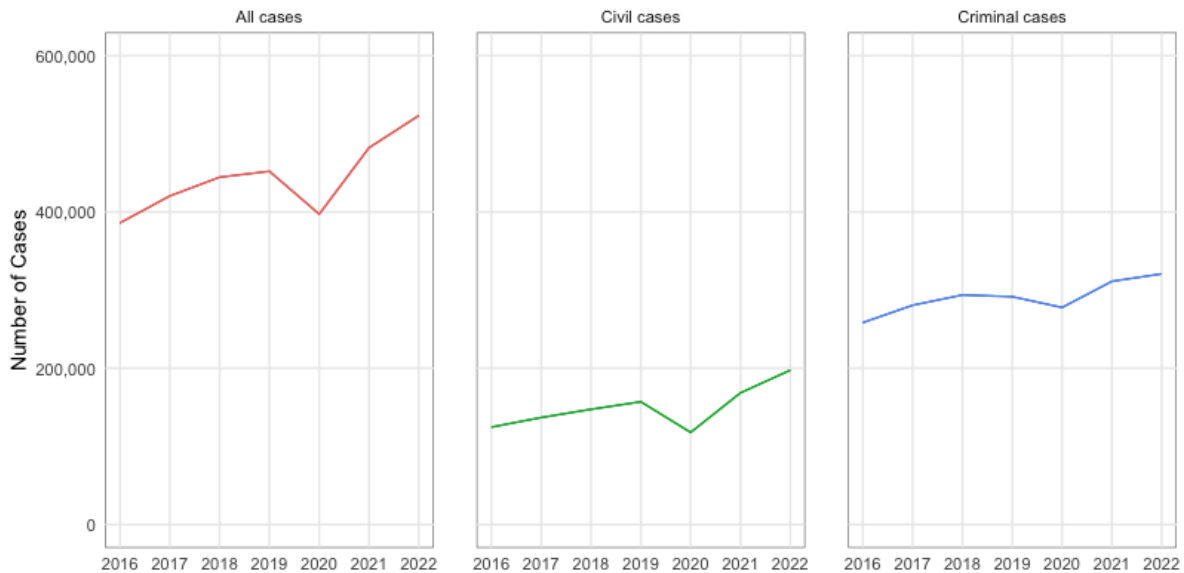
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A Data Description

A.1 Trends over Time

In this section, I show some descriptive figures. Figure A1 plots the trend of the main outcome (case filings) over the years for each case type: all, criminal and civil cases.

Figure A1: Cases trend over time

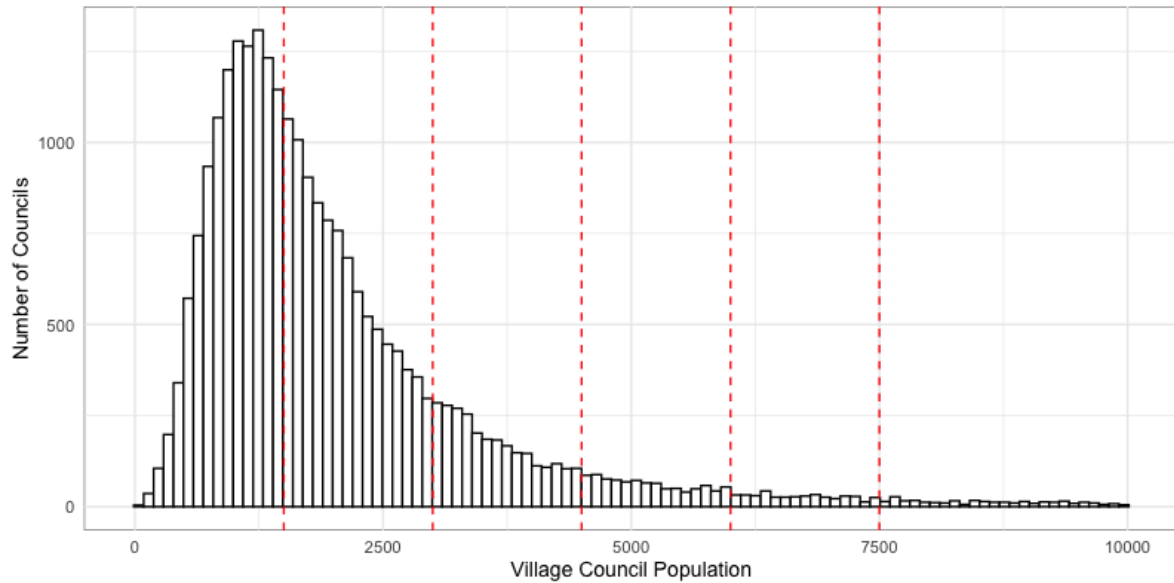


Note: The above plot shows the trend of the total number of cases in each year by category. The dip in 2020 is on account of the COVID-19 pandemic.

A.2 Distribution of Council Populations

Figure A2 shows a histogram of village council populations. Here we observe that the majority of the council data is around the 1500 cutoff, and the share of councils at each cutoff decreases at each subsequent cutoff.

Figure A2: Village Council Population Distribution



Note: Dotted red lines indicate population-based cutoffs that add two additional council members. Data representing 25,602 village councils that could be mapped to their populations using administrative datasets. Figures excludes 1.2% of councils with populations greater than 10,000.

A.3 Descriptive Statistics

Table [A1](#) shows the minimum and maximum populations for councils within each band, along with the count of villages within each band, and also displays the mean number of cases within each population band.

Table A1: Descriptive Statistics

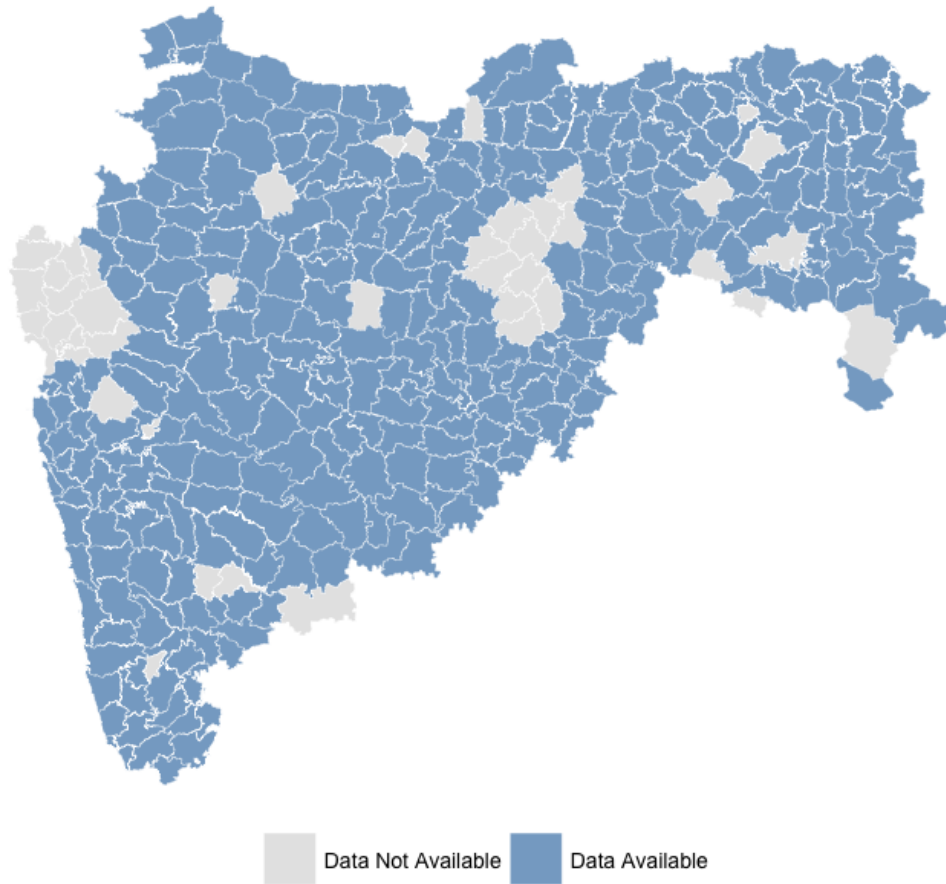
Population	Min Pop	Max Pop	Count	Members	All Cases	Civil Cases	Criminal Cases
<=1500	38	1500	11524	7	2.47	1.71	0.75
1501-3000	1501	3000	9455	9	3.41	2.13	1.26
3001-4500	3001	4499	2650	11	7.32	4.61	2.66
4501-6000	4501	6000	932	13	10.44	7.38	3.02
6001-7500	6002	7497	424	15	18.04	13.69	4.02
>=7501	7512	56491	617	17	28.78	21.73	6.93

Note: This table describes the councils in each block based on population: <1500, 1501-3000, 3001-4500, 4501-6000, 6001-7500 and >7501. Min Pop and Max Pop indicates the minimum and maximum population within the council's jurisdiction for each block. For example, for councils having a population of greater than 7500, the minimum population of such a council is 7512 while the maximum population is 56,491. Column 4 and 5 of the table indicates the number of such councils, and the council size assigned by the rule respectively. Finally, columns 6, 7, 8 denote the average the number of cases filed from councils within each category.

A.4 Spatial Distribution

To provide an overview of the data dispersion, Figure A3 plots the data availability at the sub-district level that has been analysed in the paper. In this map, I plot the sub-districts, indicating the sub-districts where the case-level data could be collected. The figure shows that the councils within the sub-districts analyzed in the main analysis are well distributed across the state. Note that the outcome data was not available for the entire districts of Hingoli, Washim, Thane and Palghar, in addition to some sub-districts. 6 sub-districts were excluded due to non-availability of data, and 11 sub-districts were excluded since the courts were created between 2016 and 2022.

Figure A3: Maharashtra Sub-District Maps: Availability of Case Data



Note: Sub-districts shaded in blue are the those for which case data from courts is available. We see from this figure that these are well-distributed across the state.

A.5 Variable Sources

The primary data used in the paper comes from a number of Indian public agencies. Further information is given in Table [A2](#).

Table A2: Data Sources

Name	Source Description	Data Provided	URL / Source
eCourts	Maharashtra District Courts	Village-level case data	https://court.mah.nic.in/courtweb/index_eng.php
LGD	Local Government Directory	Council-Village mapping	https://lgdirectory.gov.in/
shrug	Census of India 2011	Population data	https://www.devdatalab.org/shrug
Elections	Maharashtra State Election Commission	Elections data	https://mahasec.maharashtra.gov.in/ , Fieldwork by Priyadarshi Amar
REDS 2006	Rural Economic and Demographic Survey 2006	Survey data	Data provided by Andrew Foster

A.6 Outcomes

- Number of all cases 2016-2022: Number of all cases filed in lower courts in the district courts at the level of Civil Judge Junior Division, Civil Judge Senior Division or Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class for each village.
- Number of criminal cases 2016-2022: Number of criminal cases (as decided by coding rule given below) filed in lower courts in the district courts at the level of Civil Judge Junior Division, Civil Judge Senior Division or Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class for each village, as determined by case classification rule in Table A3
- Number of civil cases 2016-2022: Number of civil cases (as decided by coding rule given below) filed in lower courts in the district courts at the level of Civil Judge Junior Division, Civil Judge Senior Division or Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class for each village, as determined by case classification rule in Table A3
- Number of violence against women cases 2016-2022: Number of violence against women cases (as determined by case classification rule in Jassal (2024)) filed in lower courts in the

district courts at the level of Civil Judge Junior Division, Civil Judge Senior Division or Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class for each village.

Table A3: Rules to classify cases as civil or criminal

Case Type	Classification	Detailed Reason
R.C.S.	Civil	Regular civil suit
Civil M.A.	Civil	
M.A.C.P.	Civil	Motor accident claims
Reg Dkst	Civil	Civil court judgement
Arbitration R.D	Civil	Arbitration only for civil
Marriage Petn.	Civil	
L.A.R.	Civil	Land acquisition reference
R.C.A.	Civil	Regular civil appeal
Spl.C.S.	Civil	Special civil suit
PWDVA Appln.	Civil	Domestic violence
M.C.A.	Civil	Misc civil appeal
Spl .Dkst	Civil	Civil court judgement
MACP. Dkst.	Civil	Motor accident claims
M.J.Cases	Civil	Misc judicial cases
MACP. M.A.	Civil	Motor accident petition
Succession	Civil	Succession post deceased
Darkhast	Civil	
L.R.DKST.	Civil	
Sum.Civ.Suit	Civil	
Civil Suit	Civil	
Civil Revn.	Civil	
Civil Appeal PPE	Civil	
S.C.C.	Criminal	Summary criminal case
R.C.C.	Criminal	Regular criminal case
Cri.M.A.	Criminal	
Cri.Bail Appln.	Criminal	Bail application
Other Misc.Cri.Appln	Criminal	
Sessions Case	Criminal	Sessions court
Cri.Rev.App.	Criminal	Criminal revision application
Cri.Appeal	Criminal	Criminal appeal
Cri.Case	Criminal	
Spl Case MSEB	Criminal	MSEB theft of electricity
Cri.Municipal Appeal	Criminal	
Juvenile Cri.MA	Criminal	

A.7 Subordinate Courts

The data spans the universe of cases in the District Courts of Maharashtra.

On the Civil side, the Maharashtra Civil Courts Act²³ lays down the rules to be followed. The State Government has the power to create districts, and the presiding judge in the district is called the “District Judge”. The state government can also appoint joint or additional district judges. Further, in each district, a number of “subordinate civil courts” can be created by the state government which are subordinate to the District court. The judges practicing in these subordinate courts are called “Civil Judges”. The location of such courts and local limits of the ordinary jurisdiction are to be determined by notifications in the Official Gazette. The District Court also has appellate jurisdiction from decrees and orders of the subordinate courts.

On the Criminal side, the Code of Criminal Procedure, Maharashtra, lays down the rules to be followed²⁴. The State Government establishes a Court of Session for every session division (this is basically a district) which is presided over by a judge. Further, the state government establishes courts of Judicial Magistrates (JMs First and Second Class) across places and a particular local area has jurisdiction to try any cases or class of cases. The senior-most judge in this court is the ‘Chief Judicial Magistrate’ (CJM). The CJM is subordinate to the Sessions judge, and other JMs are subordinate to the CJM.

The data only looks at subordinate courts that are located at the sub-district (*taluka*) level - these are at the lowest level and include courts of the Civil Judge Junior Division, Civil Judge Senior Division and Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class. This helps us get around two important issues:

- (1) Maharashtra has established “District Courts” at the District Capital, and “Additional District Courts” at other locations in order to geographically spread out the higher court. The local limits of these courts are not always publicized on the website.
- (2) While aggregating civil and criminal cases, we can now be confident that they are of a similar nature
 - Civil Judge Junior Division: can hear cases that do not exceed a pecuniary value of

²³Link to Maharashtra Civil Courts Act: <https://bit.ly/mh-civil-rules>

²⁴Link to Code of Criminal Procedure, Maharashtra: <https://bit.ly/mh-crim>

500,000 INR (~ \$6000)

- Civil Judge Senior Division: can hear cases that do not exceed a pecuniary value of 1,00,000 INR (~ \$10,000)
- Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class: can try cases that involve imprisonment of less than three years or fines not exceeding ten thousand rupees

B Treatment Details

B.1 Multiple Treatments at 3000

I searched for government programs that would contaminate any of the five cutoffs. While no such programs appear to use the 1500, 4500, 6000 and 7500 cutoffs, a cutoff of 3000 is being used to determine eligibility for a number of schemes:

- (1) A nationwide development program launched in 2014 called *Saansad Adarsh Gram Yojana*²⁵, wherein each member of parliament can choose a group of villages in their constituency to implement developmental programs.
- (2) The Government of Maharashtra using the 3000 threshold to determine additional staffing for the village panchayats²⁶
- (3) The prize money for the “Tanta Mukti Scheme” (dispute-free villages) increases by 33% at the 3000 population cutoff²⁷

I thus only focus on the uncontaminated cutoffs for the main analysis.

B.2 Treatment Dose

The main results in the paper looks at treatment effects using the first cutoff. It is important to note that a number of factors change at each cutoff, most important being other policies in place and design and size of the wards. These differences are summarized in Table A4. There are other

²⁵Source: <https://bit.ly/sansad-agy>, Last Accessed: 10 July, 2025, Page archived locally.

²⁶Source: <https://bit.ly/gp-staffing>, Last Accessed: 10 July, 2025, Page archived locally.

²⁷Source: <https://bit.ly/tantamuktischeme>, Last Accessed: 10 July, 2025, Page archived locally.

policies in place at 500 and 3000 cutoffs. The 4500 and 7500 cutoffs add a new ward for the additional council members. The 6000 cutoff has more than double the ward size as compared to the first cutoff, as seen in column 4 in Table A4.

Table A4: Heterogeneity in Ward Size and Design

Threshold	Council Growth	Ward Design	Ward Size (appx)
500	—	Roads construction policy	NA
1500	7 → 9 (28% ↑)	3,2,2 → 3,3,3	500 (No change)
3000	9 → 11 (22% ↑)	3,3,3 → 3,3,3,2	1000 → 750
4500	11 → 13 (18% ↑)	3,3,3,2 → 3,3,3,2,2	1125 → 900
6000	13 → 15 (15% ↑)	3,3,3,2,2 → 3,3,3,3,3	1200 (No change)
7500	15 → 17 (13% ↑)	3,3,3,3,3 → 3,3,3,3,3,2	1500 → 1250

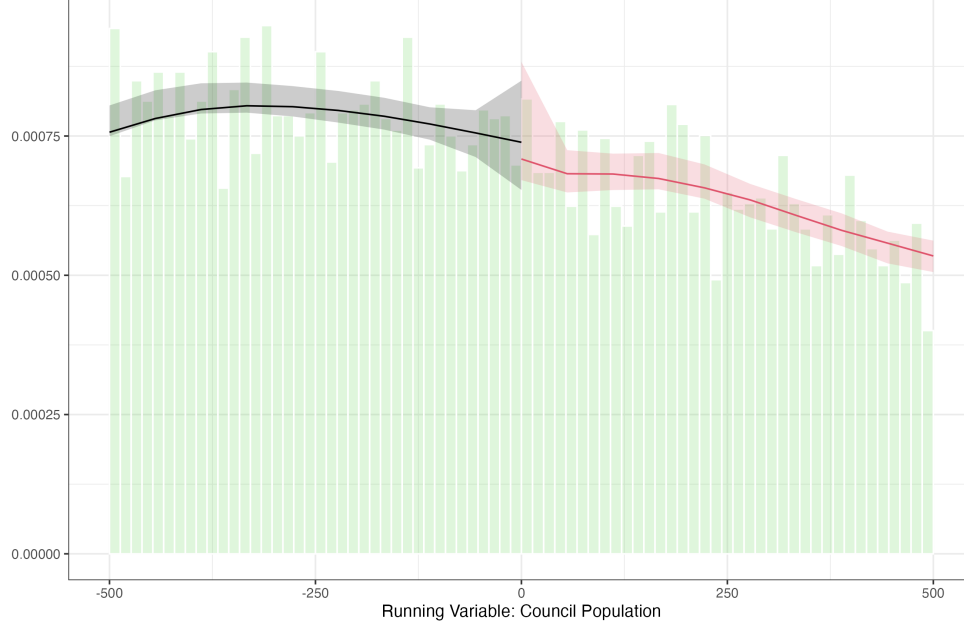
Notes: Threshold indicates population-based cutoffs. Details provide the policy in place, along with the increase in council size in brackets. Ward design indicates the number of candidates and the total number of wards. For example, 3,2,2 indicates 3 wards with the first, second and third ward electing 3, 2 and 2 members respectively. Ward size shows how the number of persons changes in each ward at the threshold; at the 1500 and 6000 threshold there is no change in ward size since the number of wards remain the same.

B.3 Regression Discontinuity Assumptions: No Sorting

The RDD is based on the assumption is that there is no manipulation (indicative of sorting) of the forcing variable (in this case, council population) near the cutoff. This would be the case if influential persons in a village were able to falsify the population numbers to allocate either fewer or greater number of members than prescribed by the design. Given that the enumerators are typically government school teachers or local officials, it might be possible for local elites to influence the enumeration process, and report lower or higher numbers if they perceive that certain benefits would be received. Another way this might happen is if people migrate to villages with either larger or smaller council sizes such that they are governed by their desired number of council members. While both these processes seem unlikely, I plot the density of the running variable and conduct a formal

test from Cattaneo, Jansson, and Ma (2020) at each of the population-based cutoffs individually. The local polynomial of degree 2 are constructed using a triangular kernel function, with jackknife standard errors.

Figure A4: Density Discontinuity Test



Notes: The plot in the figure shows the density of council population based on the 2011 census around the 1500 cutoff. Figures and tests provide evidence for the absence of discontinuities at the thresholds.

B.4 Regression Discontinuity Assumptions: Continuity

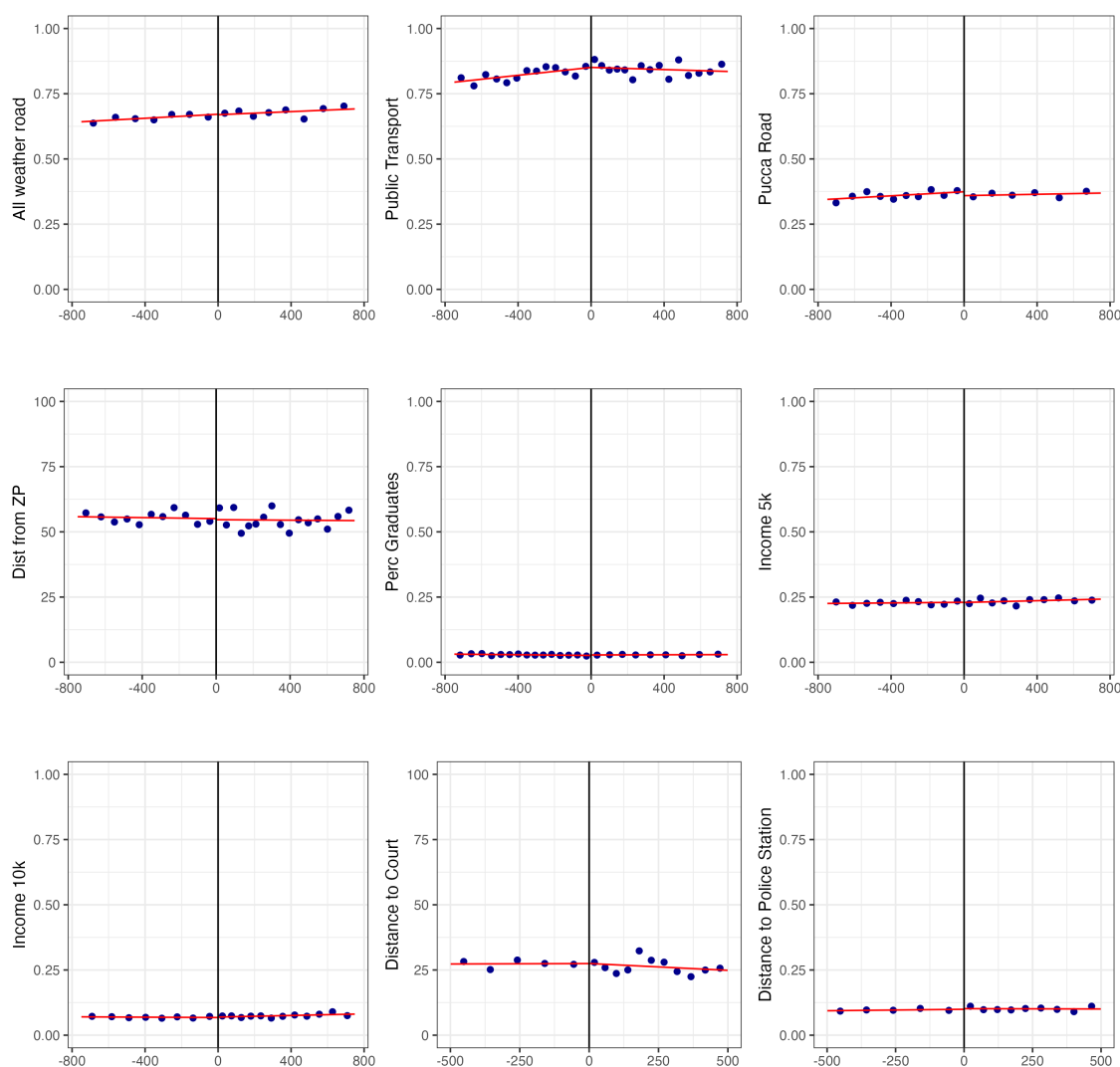
The second key identification assumption of the regression discontinuity design is that pre-treatment covariates are balanced around the population threshold. The lack of balance might imply confounding—the estimates of the treatment may be biased.

I test this assumption by collecting data from a number of data sources, particularly focusing on factors that are most likely to lead to confounding in this set-up: connectivity (availability of roads, transport and distance to headquarters), area (in square meters) governed by the council, number of graduates and high income earners. While the main paper discusses the differences between the treatment and control groups near the threshold, I visualize the data using plots here in Figure A5

Visually, it appears that a larger council is further away from the *Zilla Parishad* (ZP) that indicates the

district capital, and has a greater number of graduates. On the other hand, smaller village councils have a smaller sharer of high-income earners. Finally, in larger councils, while there appears to be a greater probability of having access to public transport, there is also a lower probability of having an all weather or internal road. There does not appear to be any conclusive evidence on the presence of large discontinuities in pre-treatment covariates.

Figure A5: Covariate Balance



Notes: Each blue dot in the figure represents an outcome (indicated on the y-axis) for each village council, based on quantile-spaced binning. Red lines denote local linear regressions. Data for the first five outcomes comes from the 2011 census, data on incomes comes from the Socio-Economic and Caste Census 2012, and data on distances (to courts and police station) computed by author.

B.5 Test for Compliance

We show compliance with the rule at each of the cutoffs. First, I assemble data for all council elections held in Maharashtra, that includes both the candidates and winners. I produce the regression discontinuity estimates on the number of politicians at each cutoff in Table A11. While we would expect that these estimates are precisely 2, they will not be perfect due to the absence of data for seats where no elections were conducted: that is, the council member was elected unopposed. This leads to missingness in the elections data. Further, while the election data is obtained directly from the State Election Commission, there were a lot of errors and inconsistencies in the data: duplicate names, incorrect/missing seats and so on. Efforts were made to reconcile it with the data on elected members from *MahaGram*: an online repository of elected members for each council. However, the lack of cleaning, maintenance and updating of these data prevents a perfect comparison. As such, all results should be interpreted as intent-to-treat estimates.

Table A5: Compliance

	Pooled	1500	3000	4500	6000	7500
LATE	1.32*** (0.26)	1.23*** (0.24)	1.56*** (0.53)	1.79*** (0.56)	0.81 (1.66)	2.87** (1.22)
Obs. (L)	4868	4106	1683	497	190	75
Obs. (R)	2612	2088	643	205	92	227
Effective Obs. (L)	1337	733	212	126	40	75
Effective Obs. (R)	1152	693	200	100	32	73
Bandwidth	257	172	163	266	183	1078
Bandwidth (Bias)	402	259	279	421	282	1381

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council level. Each observation is number of elected council members measured from a village in the 2021 elections. Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. ‘Pooled’ cutoff excludes the 3000 cutoff. Bandwidth is in number of persons. The values in brackets indicate the robust standard errors.

I use an alternate approach to show that the treatment lead to an increase in council size, leveraging an audit design from the 320 villages surveyed in A. R. Heinze, Brulé, and Chauchard (2025) and A. Heinze (2025). From this dataset, I look at 220 villages that are affected by the first cutoff. I find that assignment to treatment increases the number of council members by almost two members.

Table A6: Compliance from Survey of Village Councils

	1500 Cutoff
LATE	1.96** (0.84)
Obs. (L)	106
Obs. (R)	66
Effective Obs. (L)	35
Effective Obs. (R)	31
Bandwidth	279
Bandwidth (Bias)	406

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council level. Each observation is number of elected council members measured from a village in the survey discussed. Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. Bandwidth is in number of persons. The values in brackets indicate the robust standard errors.

C Alternate Explanations

C.1 Electoral Cycles

To explore whether the timing of elections matters, I break down the results by the number of years since the council election year - whether it is the election year and the number of years after the election.

Table [A7](#) shows a weak evidence of an election cycle for all cases: the effects are statistically significant both during the election year and in two years after the election. However, there are differences for criminal and civil cases. Table [A8](#) shows the same effect for criminal cases only—we see that the effects are strongest and statistically significant in the year of the election. Finally, [A9](#) shows the results of the analysis for civil cases. We observe that the effects of council size on access to the justice system appear to be evenly spread. These findings provide mixed evidence about how an electoral cycle plays out, and that the mechanisms could be different for criminal and civil cases.

C.2 Electoral Context and Mobilization

Perhaps one reason why members of larger councils are more effective in facilitating access to justice could relate to the electoral context. An electoral explanation for this phenomenon can be

Table A7: Results by election year for all cases

	Election Year	1 year post	2 years post	3 years post	4 years post
LATE	0.77*** (0.26)	0.49 (0.30)	0.45* (0.25)	0.38 (0.28)	0.40 (0.29)
Obs. (L)	19368	9937	7369	9580	11027
Obs. (R)	14899	7670	5717	7502	8626
Effective Obs. (L)	5949	2519	2291	2789	3382
Effective Obs. (R)	5328	2333	2046	2545	3021
Bandwidth	218	189	227	216	224
Bandwidth (Bias)	381	306	376	351	340

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council-year level. The treatment is councils with two additional members. Each observation is cases measured from a village in a particular year based on the election cycle. Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. Bandwidth is in number of persons. The values in brackets indicate the robust standard errors.

Table A8: Results by election year for criminal cases

	Election Year	1 year post	2 years post	3 years post	4 years post
LATE	0.56*** (0.18)	0.18 (0.19)	0.25 (0.18)	0.17 (0.21)	0.09 (0.21)
Obs. (L)	19368	9937	7369	9580	11027
Obs. (R)	14899	7670	5717	7502	8626
Effective Obs. (L)	4594	2519	1704	2389	3195
Effective Obs. (R)	4222	2333	1515	2154	2872
Bandwidth	172	189	172	186	213
Bandwidth (Bias)	337	302	296	306	327

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council-year level. The treatment is councils with two additional members. Each observation is cases measured from a village in a particular year based on the election cycle. Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. Bandwidth is in number of persons. The values in brackets indicate the robust standard errors.

Table A9: Results by election year for civil cases

	Election Year	1 year post	2 years post	3 years post	4 years post
LATE	0.31** (0.13)	0.25 (0.15)	0.33** (0.15)	0.26* (0.14)	0.30** (0.14)
Obs. (L)	19368	9937	7369	9580	11027
Obs. (R)	14899	7670	5717	7502	8626
Effective Obs. (L)	6745	3427	1885	2441	3012
Effective Obs. (R)	5972	3072	1669	2227	2716
Bandwidth	246	253	188	191	200
Bandwidth (Bias)	380	369	304	327	333

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council-year level. The treatment is councils with two additional members. Each observation is cases measured from a village in a particular year based on the election cycle. Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. Bandwidth is in number of persons. The values in brackets indicate the robust standard errors.

that elections to larger councils are more competitive and increase turnout from diverse groups, and the incentive to be re-elected causes members to be more engaged in their constituencies and address disputes. Further, it may be that citizens in larger councils are more politically active given that there is now a larger group of candidates per seat, and this political activity leads to greater contact with constituents, leading to a higher turnout during elections. Finally, members of larger councils can be perceived to be more legitimate by citizens, and hence citizens are more likely to approach them. I can test this by analyzing the effect of larger council sizes on the share of NOTA votes – NOTA is short for ‘None of the Above’ and such votes are cast when the voter does not support any of the candidates in council elections. Thus a greater number of NOTA votes could signal lower legitimacy and support.

I test this by analyzing the effect of larger council sizes on (1) the share of close elections (with a margin of victory less than 10%), (2) the number of contesting candidates per seat, (3) the total number of contesting candidates (4) number of citizens turning out to vote and (5) the share of votes that are cast as a NOTA vote.

Table A10 indicates that elections to larger council sizes are not more competitive, and do not have greater number of candidates contesting per seat, or changes legitimacy of candidates, captured by the share of NOTA votes cast by voters. On the other hand, we observe a statistically significant

18% increase in turnout, and on average, we see about 3 more candidates contesting the elections.

Table A10: Larger councils and electoral context

	Close Elections	Candidates per Seat	Total Candidates	Turnout	NOTA
LATE	0.001 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.03)	3.34*** (0.71)	379.64*** (83.52)	0.001 (0.001)
Obs. (L)	38599	38884	6105	6942	6942
Obs. (R)	30343	30564	3923	4404	4404
Effective Obs. (L)	10174	13669	1787	1518	1503
Effective Obs. (R)	11184	14242	1589	1412	1385
Bandwidth	191	248	212	163	161
Bandwidth (Bias)	288	378	314	261	258

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council-year level. The treatment is councils with two additional members. Each observation measured from a council during an election. Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. Bandwidth is in number of persons. The values in brackets indicate the robust standard errors.

C.3 Council size does not change police-related functions

One alternate explanation for the increased criminal cases is that additional council members are able to strengthen other functions pertaining to the police. For example, adding council capacity might increase their effectiveness in recruiting a village police officer (known as a police patil). I use the same data of 220 villages for which a survey was conducted in Maharashtra (A. Heinze 2025; A. R. Heinze, Brulé, and Chauchard 2025), and I find that assignment to treatment has no statistically significant effect on whether a police patil is recruited.

C.4 Council size does not change trust in institutions

An alternate explanation that explains the increase in citizens accessing courts is that increasing council size increases trust in institutions. I show that this is not the case, using descriptive analysis that uses data from the *Indian Human Development Survey-II* in Table A12.

Each respondent is a head of the household. ‘Confidence in Police’ and ‘Confidence in Courts’ are outcomes that take the value 1 if the respondent selects “a great deal of confidence”, as opposed

Table A11: Does village have a police patil?

	0=Yes / 1 = No
LATE	-0.05 (0.35)
Obs. (L)	105
Obs. (R)	62
Effective Obs. (L)	24
Effective Obs. (R)	26
Bandwidth	232
Bandwidth (Bias)	363

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council level. Each observation indicates whether a police patil has been recruited from the village in the survey discussed. Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. Bandwidth is in number of persons. The values in brackets indicate the robust standard errors.

to “only some” or “hardly any confidence”. ‘Panchayat member close to household’ takes value 1 if a panchayat member or official is within or close to the household. The results indicate that while respondents in larger councils report that they have access to a council member close to their household, a larger number of members is not associated with greater confidence in the police or courts.

Table A12: Effect of Council Size on Trust in Institutions

	Panchayat member close to household	Confidence in Police	Confidence in Courts
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Number of Council Members	0.007** (0.003)	-0.0001 (0.002)	-0.0004 (0.001)
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Religion FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Caste Category FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	15,407	15,407	15,407
R ²	0.180	0.056	0.051

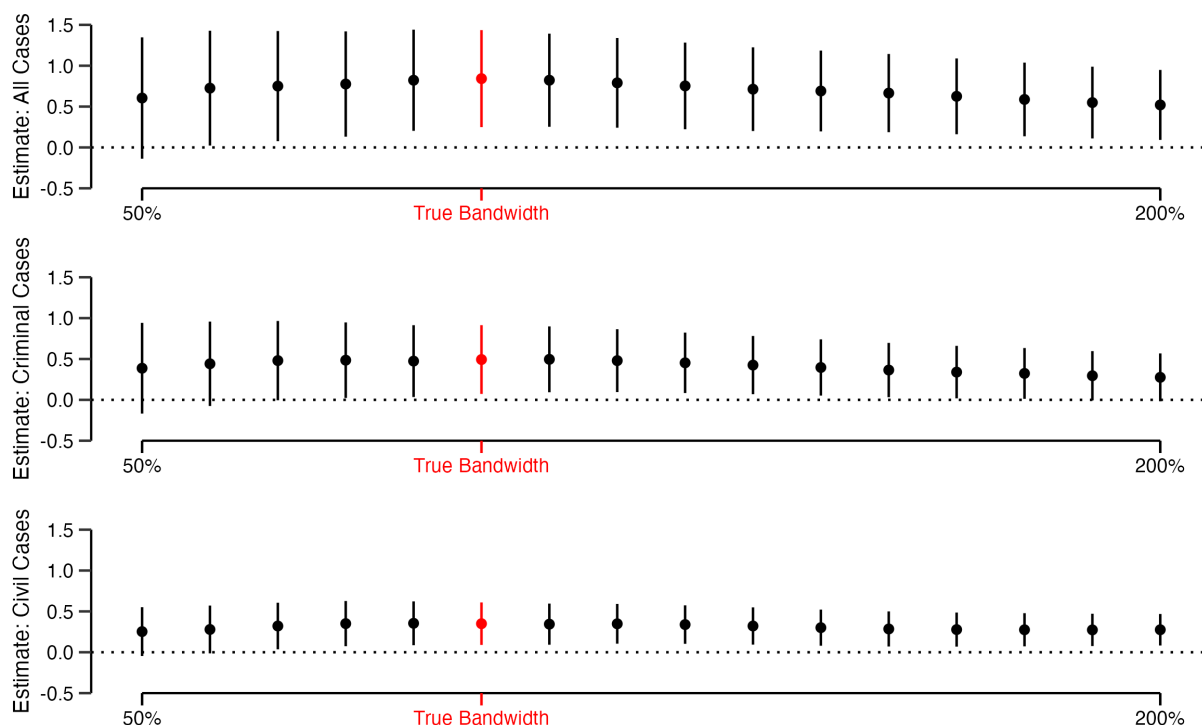
Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the village level. The independent variable is the reported number of council members.

D Sensitivity Analysis

D.1 Sensitivity to Bandwidth Choice

In this section, I present sensitivity tests for bandwidth selection. I follow the suggestions of Bueno and Tunon (2015)²⁸ and vary bandwidth from 50% to 200% of the Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik (2014) estimate in Figure A6. We see that our results are not sensitive to the choice of bandwidth.

Figure A6: Results not sensitive choice of bandwidth



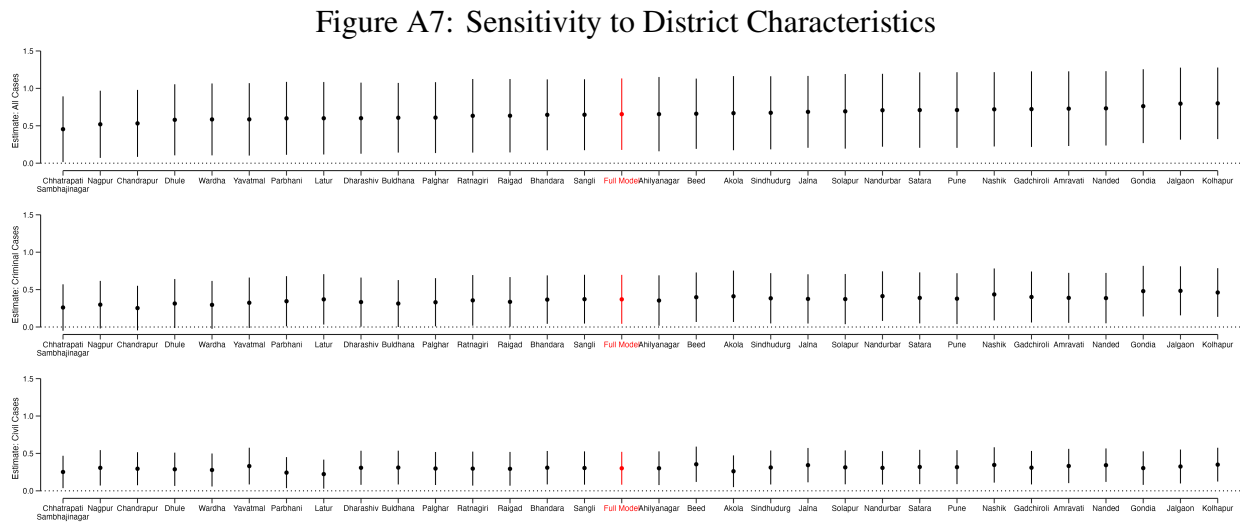
Note: The above plot shows the sensitivity to bandwidth choice for the three main outcomes.

D.2 Sensitivity to District Characteristics

Due to the large size of the state, Maharashtra has a lot of geographic variation. For instance, some districts could be more geographically compact that allows individuals to access courts easily as compared to districts that are more geographically spread out. A concern of this is that the results

²⁸Graphical Presentation of Regression Discontinuity Results, The Society for Political Methodology Blog. Available at: <https://bit.ly/rd-link>

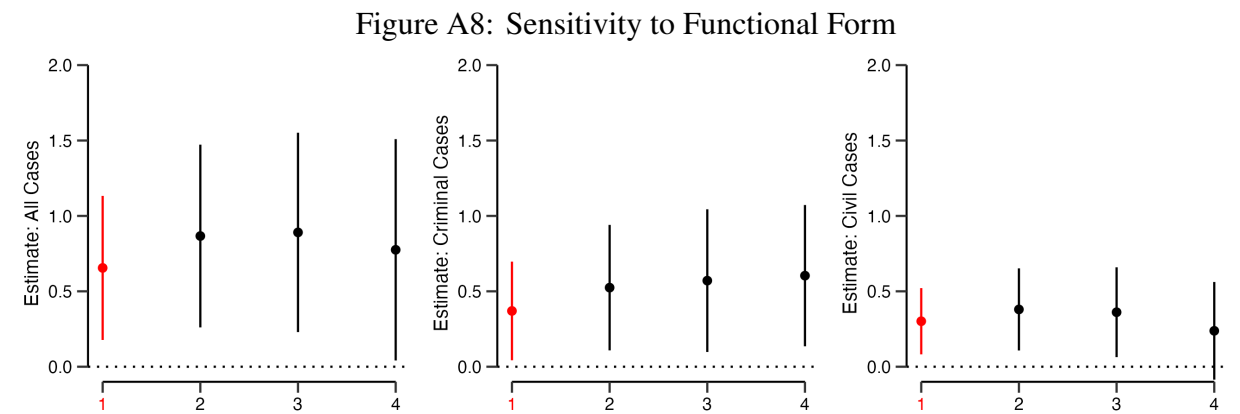
could be driven by the inclusion of an outlier district that skews the average. I run the analysis by dropping one district at a time to investigate if the results are sensitive to the presence of such a district. The results in Figure A7 show that the estimates remain robust.



Note: The above plots show the sensitivity to district characteristics by each case category separately – that is, for all cases, criminal cases and civil cases.

D.3 Sensitivity to Functional Form

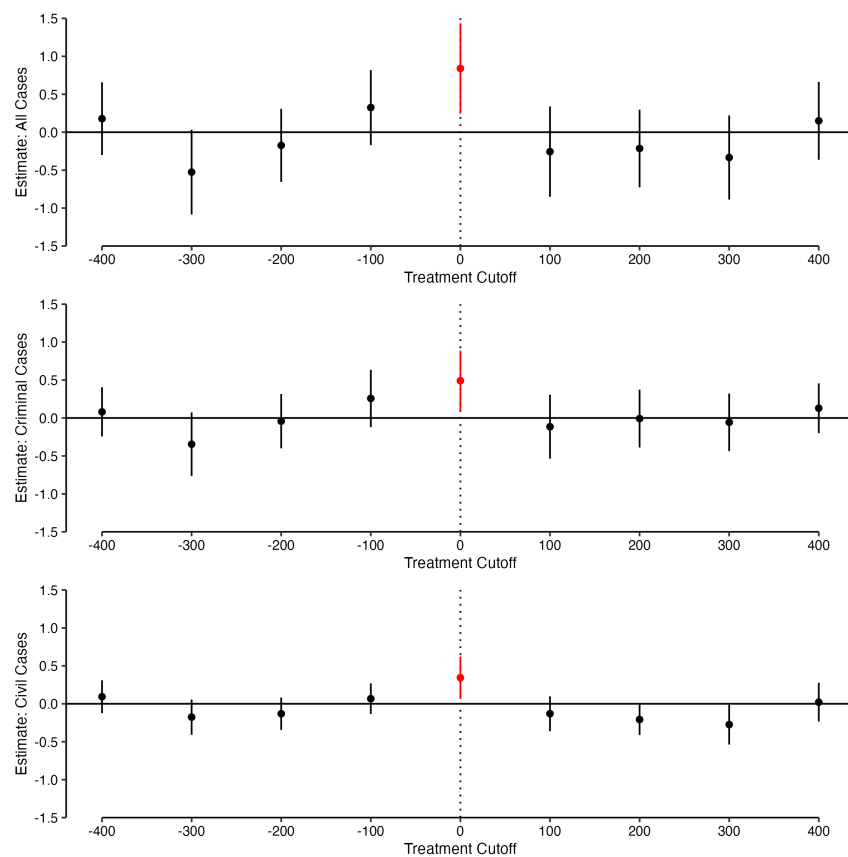
In Figure A8, I show that the results remain robust to changing the functional form: using linear ($p=1$), quadratic ($p=2$), cubic ($p=3$) and quartic ($p=4$).



D.4 Results at placebo cut-offs

In Figure A9, I perform placebo tests to show the relationship between the running variable and the case filing at cutoffs other than the true cutoff. To do this, I re-estimate the regression discontinuity estimates at placebo cutoffs. I generate placebo cutoffs incrementally by adding or subtracting 100 on either side of the true population cutoff that determines the treatment. There are no significant LATE estimates for these placebo cutoffs, showing that there are no significant discontinuities in the outcome for placebo values of the running variable.

Figure A9: Placebo Tests at Different Cutoffs



Note: Results in red indicate the true cutoff, and those in black are computed at placebo cutoffs. Plots indicate bias-corrected point estimate and robust standard errors.

D.5 Robustness using Regression Discontinuity Aggregation

In order to conduct the analysis at the council level, I exclude cases that are filed from litigants in multiple villages. This reduces the sample that I can analyse to 35%. In this section, I show

robustness to using all the cases filed, through an analysis at the sub-district level using the Regression Discontinuity Aggregation method (Borusyak and Kolerman-Shemer 2025).

In this analysis, I aggregate all the cases filed at the sub-district denoted by i . To estimate the effects of larger sized councils, I first calculate the fraction of treated units in the sub-district (X_i), that is, the ratio of councils that are assigned a larger council to the total number of councils in the sub-district. I instrument this by using the fraction of treated councils that are close to the 1500 cutoff, using the bandwidths estimated (Z_i). Further, to interpret the results as local causal effects at the upper level of aggregation (the sub-district level), I add the RDA controls as suggested in Borusyak and Kolerman-Shemer (2025). In my analysis, these variables are the share of councils within the cutoff relative to the total number of councils in a sub-district (c_1), the average of the running variable within the cutoff (c_2), and the average of the running variables for the treated units within the cutoff (c_3).

I use an instrumental variables strategy leveraging RD aggregation using the following specification:

$$\text{First Stage: } X_i = \gamma_0 + \rho_1 Z_i + \gamma_1 \text{Population}_i + \gamma_2 c_{1i} + \gamma_3 c_{2i} + \gamma_4 c_{3i} + \eta_i \quad (4)$$

$$\text{Second Stage: } \text{Cases}_i = \beta_0 + \rho \hat{X}_i + \beta_1 \text{Population}_i + \beta_2 c_{1i} + \beta_3 c_{2i} + \beta_4 c_{3i} + \epsilon_i \quad (5)$$

From Table A15, we see that larger councils lead to greater case filings for all three case types. Since the treatment is a fraction and to make this estimate comparable with the treatment analysed in the paper, I multiple the estimated effects by 0.26 to understand the effect of a 26% increase in treated units.

Table A14 shows that a 26% increase in the number of treated councils corresponds to a 45.4% increase in the number of cases filed at the sub-district level. Similarly, a 26% increase in the number of treated councils corresponds to a 29.4% increase in the number of criminal cases filed and a 56.9% increase in the number of civil cases filed. While the interpretation of the treatment at the sub-district is slightly different from that analysed in the main paper, it is nevertheless confirms that the effects are not driven due to exclusion of cases filed from more than one village.

Table A13: Regression Discontinuity Results: Sub-District Level

	Total Cases	Criminal Cases	Civil Cases
Z	2,512.239** (1,102.368)	1,404.411* (766.597)	1,065.818*** (407.061)
Population	0.005*** (0.001)	0.003*** (0.001)	0.002*** (0.0004)
c_1	1,167.116* (648.392)	999.056** (450.897)	171.014 (239.425)
c_2	-1.589 (1.179)	-0.895 (0.820)	-0.694 (0.435)
c_3	-1.054 (1.597)	-0.674 (1.111)	-0.376 (0.590)
District FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mean of DV	1437.691	941.511	486.252
First-stage F-stat	135.29	135.29	135.29
Observations	2,128	2,128	2,128
R ²	0.211	0.206	0.290

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Each observation is the number of cases measured from a taluka in each year. The total elected members is the total number of council members serving within the sub-district.

Table A14: Interpreting Magnitude of IV Estimates (Effect of a 26% Increase in X)

Category	Coefficient	Effect of +0.26 in X	% of Mean DV
Total Cases	2,512.24	+653.12 cases	45.4%
Criminal Cases	1,404.41	+365.04 cases	29.4%
Civil Cases	1,065.82	+276.9 cases	56.9%

Note: The mean dependent variables for the sample are 1,437.7, 941.5, and 486.3 respectively. X is measured as a fraction (0–1).

D.6 Robustness subsetting to low-missingness sub-districts

Another concern with these data is that there are lots of missing cases. This can be assessed by taking advantage of the fact that each case number is assigned in a sequence of numbers in the form of serialized data (Wu et al. 2026). For each sub-district, this allows me to assess how many cases could be missing. On average for each sub-district, it appears that 26% of data is missing. Figure A10 illustrates this in two sub-districts, one evaluated as having low amount of missing data and one with relatively higher missing data.

Figure A10: Using sequence of case numbers to quantify missingness



I replicate the results using the regression discontinuity aggregation design, only focusing on the subset of sub-districts where the data is of very high quality. That is, I subset to sub-districts where any possible missingness accounts for fewer than 10% of observed cases. I find that the results are robust in both interpretation and magnitude on subsetting to the sub-districts wherein the data is high quality and reliable.

Table A15: Regression Discontinuity Results: Sub-District Level (Low Missingness Sub-Districts Only)

	Total Cases	Criminal Cases	Civil Cases
Z	5,134.500*** (1,648.808)	3,750.617*** (1,181.421)	1,350.144*** (487.863)
Population	−0.00003 (0.001)	−0.001 (0.001)	0.0005 (0.0004)
c ₁	−1,727.924 (1,347.032)	−1,145.011 (965.190)	−564.352 (398.571)
c ₂	−0.902 (2.643)	−0.416 (1.894)	−0.474 (0.782)
c ₃	−3.511 (2.407)	−2.417 (1.725)	−1.086 (0.712)
District FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mean of DV	1193.285	848.995	338.758
First-stage F-stat	103.47	103.47	103.47
Observations	784	784	784
R ²	0.062	−0.007	0.287

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Each observation is the number of cases measured from a taluka in each year, restricting to talukas with less than 10

D.7 Alternate Design

In this section, I analyse an alternate design focusing on newly formed councils. There are about 2221 new councils that were formed between 2018 and 2022. These new councils are created by taking the local areas that form the older council, and splitting them into two or more councils. For example, in June 2025, a council comprising three villages: Panchala (Bk), Panchala (Kh) and Guguldosh, in Ramtek, Nagpur, was split into two groups: the first group named Panchala (Bk) comprised of Panchala (Bk) and Panchala (Kh), while the second group named Gugoldoh comprised of the Gugaldoh village²⁹.

While some of these newly created councils get assigned a smaller council size (based on the same population thresholds), others get assigned a larger council size with two additional members. I run the main analysis for these villages only in Table A16. We observe partially consistent results here – having two additional council members increases the number of cases filed from the newly formed councils with larger councils, however the effects are not statistically significant.

Table A16: Newly Formed Councils

	All cases	Criminal	Civil
LATE	0.08 (0.50)	0.24 (0.26)	−0.07 (0.30)
Obs. (L)	2118	2118	2118
Obs. (R)	1568	1568	1568
Effective Obs. (L)	793	591	650
Effective Obs. (R)	595	419	433
Bandwidth	261	204	212
Bandwidth (Bias)	414	334	357

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council level. Each observation is number of cases measured from a village for each year. Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. Bandwidth is in number of persons.

²⁹Details obtained from Maharashtra Rural Development Ministry Website, <http://bit.ly/4lpGN8u>, Last Accessed on 10 July, 2025. Page archived for reference. Notifications for several other examples can be accessed on the ‘Notifications’ page here: <http://bit.ly/4IREWsZ>

E Additional details

E.1 Rural Economic and Demographic Survey Questions Used

I accessed data from the Rural Economic and Demographic Survey conducted in 2005-06 by obtaining a minimal risk research IRB approval from the University of Wisconsin–Madison. I submitted the same to Dr. Andrew Foster, who shared the restricted data for the 2005-06 years.

Below, I reproduce the exact wording of the questions from which the outcomes are constructed for the difference-in-differences analysis. Each response takes an ordinal outcome taking values between 1 and 4, with 1 being the highest rating for the question [High=1; Medium=2; Low=3; Not aware=4].

1. Honesty: Evaluation of Elected Representatives [Honesty and fairness: p83q3, p83q4]
2. Qualifications: Evaluation of Elected Representatives [Technical qualifications of the candidate: p83q9, p83q10]
3. Solve social problems: Evaluation of Elected Representatives [Ability to solve social problems, such as disputes over land, marriage etc: p83q18, p83q19]
4. Solve local problems: Evaluation of Elected Representatives [Ability to solve local problems such as roads, education, water etc: p83q15, p83q16]

E.2 Qualitative Interview Questionnaire

In Summer 2025, I conducted interviews with 19 council members in Maharashtra. I started with collecting the contact details of currently serving council members in Maharashtra, from which I drew a random sample of 100 contact numbers. I then hired an agency to reach out to the phone numbers and ask the following questions:

1. How many years have you been a council member?
2. Do villagers come to you to solve disputes?
 - a. What kinds of disputes do you not attempt to resolve?

- b. What types of cases do villagers typically approach you to resolve?
 - c. What types of cases do villagers typically not approach you to resolve?
3. There is a property dispute in a family in your village. They approach you for help. How do you help them?
 4. There is a murder in your village. You are approached by the family of the deceased for help. How do you help them?
 5. Why do you help villagers with their problems?
 6. Do you know any lawyers or anyone from the police force? How?

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